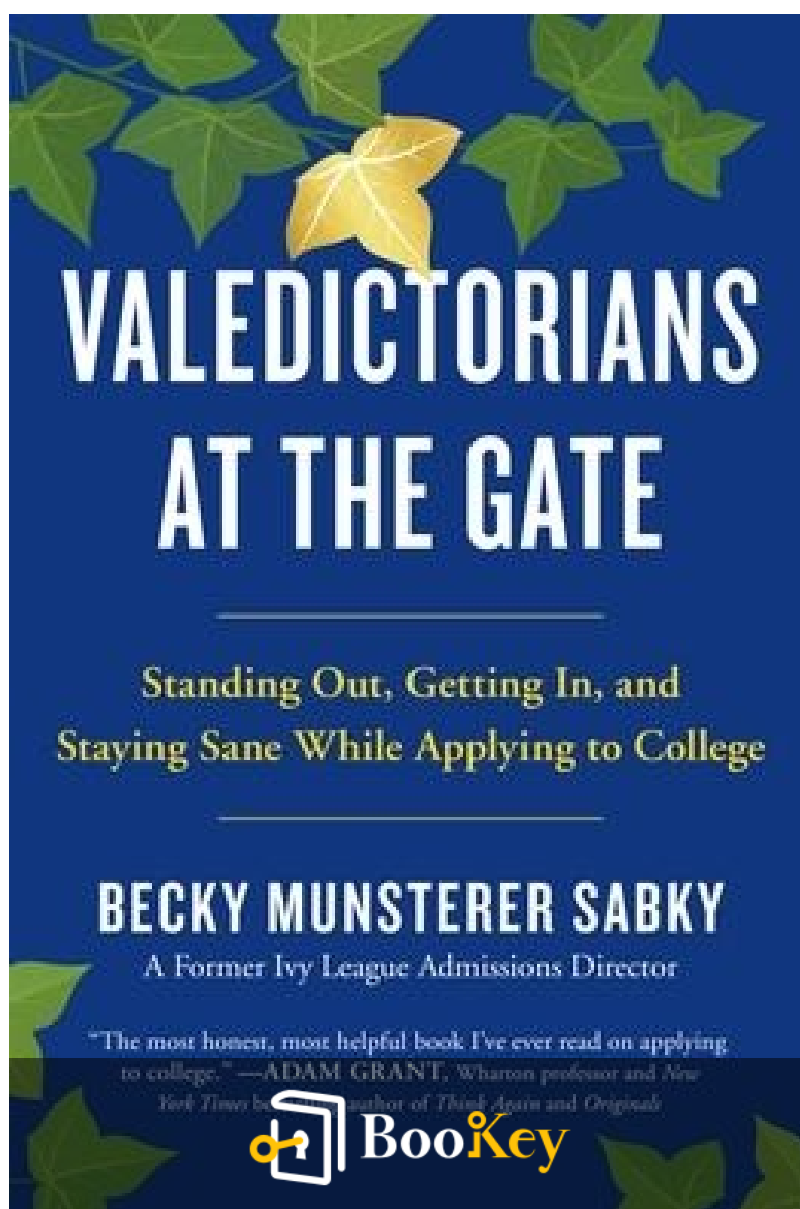


Valedictorians at the Gate PDF

Becky Munsterer Sabky



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Valedictorians at the Gate

Navigating College Admissions with Clarity and Purpose.

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About the book

In "Valedictorians at the Gate," former Ivy League admissions officer Becky Munsterer Sabky delivers a refreshing perspective on the college application process. Drawing from her extensive experience at Dartmouth, Sabky emphasizes the importance of self-discovery over mere competition, urging students to seek the school that truly fits their unique needs and aspirations. This engaging guide offers practical advice for both students and parents, steering them away from the pressure of rankings and toward a more meaningful college journey. Witty, warm, and full of insight, "Valedictorians at the Gate" is an essential resource for any student feeling overwhelmed by the admissions landscape, encouraging them to find their ideal educational match.

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About the author

Becky Munsterer Sabky is a writer and educator known for her insightful exploration of the college admissions process, which she delves into in her acclaimed book "Valedictorians at the Gate." With a background in both education and journalism, Sabky combines her expertise to provide a nuanced perspective on the pressures faced by students and families during this pivotal time. Her work aims to demystify the often intimidating college application landscape, offering guidance and encouragement to aspiring college students. Through her writing, Sabky engages readers with relatable anecdotes and practical advice, making her a respected voice in the conversation surrounding higher education and the aspirations of young scholars.

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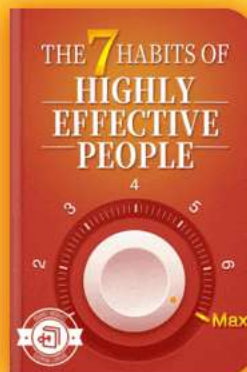
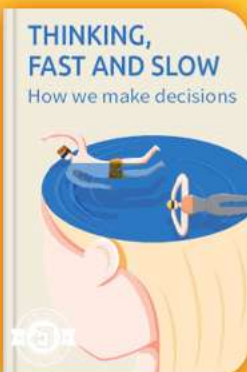


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Chapter 1 Summary : First Steps



CHAPTER TWO: FIRST STEPS

Introduction to College Conversations

- Learning about college is a gradual process similar to discussing adolescence.
- Families often feel anxious about when to start the college process, with competitive admissions prompting a desire to start early.

When to Start the College Process

- Junior year is typically when students begin college

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applications.

- Families should engage in proactive steps by the middle of junior year to avoid last-minute stress during senior year.

Understanding College Basics

- Students should familiarize themselves with the fundamentals of college: definitions of college vs. university, financial aid concepts, and the nature of liberal arts curriculums.
- A well-rounded perspective on college should precede obsession with prestigious institutions.

The Importance of Thoughtful Engagement

- College preparation should be a relaxed exploration rather than a frantic race.
- Parents should initiate broad discussions about college, rather than formal "conversations."

Encouraging Early Interest in College

- The excitement about college can spark from informal situations, like family discussions during sports events.

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- Issues related to college admissions should be accessible topics to discuss in everyday life.

Addressing Freshman Concerns

- Speaking to freshmen about college can be daunting; it often generates anxiety about grades and preparations.
- A presentation aimed at encouraging college readiness should focus on engaging underclassmen without overwhelming them.

Key Tips for High School Freshmen

1.

Challenging Coursework

: Choose classes that are appropriate for academic growth rather than settling for easy options.

2.

Utilize Counseling Resources

: Meet with school counselors early to understand high school requirements and opportunities.

3.

Writing Skills Development

: Focus on writing to strengthen not only college applications

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but academic performance as well.

Engaging Students in Discussions

- Conversations about college admissions often require engagement strategies to maintain student interest.
- Students may have some knowledge about competitive colleges but need more comprehensive understanding without fostering anxiety.

Perspective on College Readiness

- Each student's timeline for interest in college will vary; parents should focus more on cultivating high school experiences rather than overly stressing college preparedness.
- A balanced approach encourages students to find their interests while also laying the groundwork for future college applications.

Final Takeaway

- High school is the foundation for college; success in high school translates directly to opportunities in college.
- The most significant preparation for college is ensuring a

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meaningful high school experience, focusing on learning and personal development over mere résumé building.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The timing and nature of college preparation should be a balanced exploration rather than a high-pressure race.

Critical Interpretation: The author stresses that families should engage in college conversations at a measured pace, ideally starting in the junior year, to avoid the anxiety of last-minute preparations. However, this perspective may overlook the individuality of each student's journey and the varying family dynamics that could affect this process. For instance, some students may thrive under pressure and excel when admissions timelines are tightly structured. Critics of this viewpoint might argue that early intervention can be beneficial for those who need direction, as highlighted in studies dealing with educational psychology, such as 'Mindset' by Carol Dweck, which discusses how perceived pressure can influence student motivation and performance.

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Chapter 2 Summary : Creating the Right College List



Section	Summary
Chapter Title	Creating the Right College List
Importance of College List	Creating a college list is essential as there are over 5,000 institutions in the U.S.
College Selection Process	Research is vital; motivations for choosing colleges vary, and a diverse list is necessary.
Key Steps	Broaden Options: Include multiple schools to enhance happiness; avoid fixation on one college. Assess Admissions Data: Use testing scores and admission rates to evaluate schools. Evaluate Financial Realities: Discuss costs and use net price calculators for estimation. Prioritize Genuine Interest: Apply only to schools the student truly wants to attend.
Open Mind Importance	Stay open-minded in the selection process; real-life examples show drawbacks of focusing only on prestigious institutions.
Final Thoughts	Reflect on personal interests and opportunities; prioritize genuine excitement over rankings in choosing colleges.

CHAPTER THREE: CREATING THE RIGHT

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COLLEGE LIST

Creating a college list is a crucial step for students preparing for higher education. With over five thousand institutions in the U.S., and just a few hundred often highlighted in popular guides, students must approach this task thoughtfully.

Understanding the College Selection Process

- A college-bound student needs to conduct thorough research before finalizing their list of schools.
- There are various reasons why students choose particular colleges, but not all motivations are rooted in genuine interest.
- The importance of a diverse college list is emphasized, incorporating various admission competitiveness levels.

Key Steps in Creating a College List

1.

Broaden Your Options

: It's essential to have multiple schools on the list to avoid limiting potential happiness. Students can apply early decision but should not fixate on one institution.

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2.

Assess Admissions Data

: Utilize average standardized testing scores and admission rates to gauge a school's competitiveness and fit.

3.

Evaluate Financial Realities

: Families should discuss the costs and affordability of institutions to ensure that financial constraints do not limit options. Tools like net price calculators can assist in estimating expenses.

4.

Prioritize Genuine Interest

: Students should only apply to colleges they genuinely wish to attend, avoiding the label of "safety schools." Every option should be an appealing choice rather than a fallback.

The Importance of an Open Mind

Real-life experiences exemplify the need for an open mindset when crafting a college list. A story of a student, Marco, illustrates the potential pitfalls of applying to only prestigious colleges without considering other valuable institutions. His eventual choice reflected a lack of

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enthusiasm, underscoring the need for students to pursue schools that excite them.

Final Thoughts on College Choices

College is a privilege that holds transformative potential. Students are encouraged to reflect critically on their options, focusing on personal opportunities rather than rankings, and to embrace schools that spark their interest and aspirations. By doing thorough research and maintaining an open mind, students can ensure they make choices that resonate with them personally.

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Example

Key Point:Diversify Your College Options

Example:Imagine you're standing at a crossroads with multiple paths before you; if you only choose the one leading to a prestigious institution, you might overlook hidden gems that truly match your passions and interests. By broadening your college list and including a variety of schools, you open doors to experiences that resonate with who you are, rather than who you're expected to be. Taking this time to explore and evaluate all your options acts as a ticket to a future filled with excitement and fulfillment.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Diversifying the College List Can Prevent Disappointment

Critical Interpretation: While the author posits the importance of having a varied college list to enhance student happiness and ensure more successful admissions, this perspective may overlook the value some students find in applying to highly selective institutions. There's merit to the argument that a wider range of options can inspire enthusiasm and a sense of genuineness in the application process; however, one might question if this leads to complacency at the expense of striving toward top-tier goals. Sources such as "The Price of Admission" by Daniel Golden acknowledge that successful college applications often stem from ambitious pursuits, suggesting that not every student will benefit equally from a broader list. While a well-rounded approach is prudent, the pressure to balance aspiration with pragmatism becomes crucial.

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Chapter 3 Summary : The Campus Visit

Section	Summary
Overview of College Tours	College tours offer a blend of practicality and whimsy, revealing the true spirit and aspects of campus life that brochures often miss.
Importance of Research and Preparation	Students should engage in thorough research if in-person visits aren't possible, including reading campus newspapers, consulting course catalogs, and contacting admissions offices.
Maximizing Campus Visits	Strategic planning for visits includes attending classes, registering with admissions, and exploring the campus beyond scheduled events for a deeper understanding.
Gaining Authentic Perspectives	Campus visits help students assess their fit for the college; proactive exploration enhances application essays with unique insights.
Building Connections and Gathering Insights	Engaging with current students and faculty provides deeper understanding of academic and social life; observing campus culture is also beneficial.
Conclusion: The Value of Exploration	Campus visits are about personal exploration and understanding if the college meets student needs. Engaging with the community can lead to informed decisions and stronger applications.

Chapter Four: The Campus Visit

Overview of College Tours

College visits in America are beloved for their blend of practicality and whimsy. These tours provide insight into a college's spirit that brochures cannot capture, revealing both the attractive and less appealing aspects of campus life.

Importance of Research and Preparation

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Not everyone can visit colleges in person, but students should engage in thorough research regardless.

Recommended activities include:

- Reading online campus newspapers and op-eds for insights on student life.
- Consulting course catalogs for specific major requirements.
- Contacting admissions offices for resources for those unable to visit.

Maximizing Campus Visits

For those who can visit, it's crucial to plan strategically:

- Visit during class sessions to experience daily campus life.
- Register with the admissions office to express demonstrated interest.
- Explore campus beyond the scheduled events to gain a deeper understanding, including:
 - Dining in the campus dining hall to witness social

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Chapter 4 Summary : Coming to a High School Near You

Section	Summary
Chapter Title	Coming to a High School Near You
Author's Role	An admissions officer sharing experiences in student recruitment
Key Focus	The importance of regional representation in the admissions process
Activities	Traveling to meet prospective students, understanding school environments
Benefit for Applicants	Knowing the admissions officer can enhance their application process
Notable Student	Layla, a curious and engaging student with insightful questions
Memorable Qualities	Personality traits, curiosity, and how candidates treat others
Contrast Explored	Traditional academic success vs. personal qualities
Encouragement for Students	To interact with admissions officers and share unique stories
Conclusion	Layla did not apply, highlighting unpredictable admissions processes

Chapter Summary: Coming to a High School Near You

In this chapter, the author, an admissions officer, shares her experiences recruiting students across various regions, highlighting the importance of regional representation in the admissions process. Over several weeks each fall and spring, she travels to meet prospective students, forming connections and understanding different school environments.

While visiting schools, the author emphasizes that knowing

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the admissions officer can benefit applicants, as this person plays a crucial role in reviewing and presenting their applications. Despite the vast number of students encountered each year, she specifically recalls Layla, a curious and engaging student who stood out due to her insightful questions and passion for learning.

The chapter explores the dynamics of student interactions and the impressionable qualities that make candidates memorable—traits that stem from their personalities, curiosity, and how they treat others. It reflects on the contrast between traditional expectations of academic success and the value of personal qualities.

Ultimately, the author encourages students to interact with admissions officers, share their unique stories and interests, and express their desire to connect. The narrative concludes with a note of regret that Layla did not apply to the college, signifying the unpredictable nature of the admissions process and the potential missed opportunities for unique candidates.

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Example

Key Point: The importance of personal connection in the college admissions process.

Example: Imagine attending a college fair, surrounded by peers, and stumbling upon an admissions officer who has visited your school. You seize the chance to introduce yourself, share your interests, and ask thoughtful questions, making a memorable impression. This simple interaction might not seem crucial at the time, but it can shape your application's perception when it crosses the officer's desk, highlighting just how vital these relationships are.

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Chapter 5 Summary : The School Report

Section	Summary
Contextual Considerations in Admissions	Students question the value of grades in AP vs. honors classes and the importance of class ranking, with admissions officers considering academic context.
School Types and College Preferences	Top colleges value students from various educational backgrounds equally, whether from prestigious private schools or underfunded public schools.
School and Counselor Influence	Experienced college counselors can provide an advantage, but many students face limited personalized support in larger schools.
Navigating the Admissions Process	Colleges expect students to maximize learning opportunities, assessing individual achievements rather than school prestige.
Understanding Academic Submissions	College applications include transcripts, high school profiles, and counselor recommendations that provide context for academic history.
Effective Self-Advocacy	Students should engage with counselors and submit additional context for unusual grades, emphasizing personal growth and challenges.
Choosing Authentic Interests	Admissions offices prefer students who pursue their genuine interests over courses that only impress, advocating for meaningful learning experiences.
Defending Academic Choices	Students should advocate for their educational paths, focusing on personal fulfillment and intellectual curiosity over traditional metrics of success.

THE SCHOOL REPORT

Contextual Considerations in Admissions

As students approach college admissions, they ponder the significance of their academic choices, questioning whether it is better to achieve a B in an AP class or an A in an honors class and whether class ranking matters more in competitive or less competitive schools. Admissions officers do consider

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the context of a student's academic background.

School Types and College Preferences

Families often inquire about the perceived advantages of different school types, such as those offering AP or IB programs and specialized STEM schools. However, top colleges like Dartmouth tend to value students from a variety of educational backgrounds equally, admitting candidates from both prestigious private schools and underfunded public schools.

School and Counselor Influence

Students from schools with experienced college counselors may have an edge, as these counselors are adept in navigating college admissions and may engage in “counselor calls” with colleges to discuss applicants. However, most students attend larger schools with overloaded counselors, limiting personalized support.

Navigating the Admissions Process

While some students have the luxury of choosing their high

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school based on perceived advantages for college admissions, many do not. Colleges expect students to maximize their learning opportunities regardless of their high school's resources. Admissions committees aim to assess students based on their individual achievements and context rather than solely on the prestige of their school.

Understanding Academic Submissions

College applications typically consist of a transcript, a high school profile, and counselor recommendations.

Understanding these components can help applicants present their academic history clearly. High school profiles provide context on grading systems, available courses, and graduation requirements, which can help admissions officers interpret transcripts accurately.

Effective Self-Advocacy

Students are encouraged to engage actively with their counselors and, if needed, submit additional letters to provide context for unusual grades or curricular choices.

Emphasizing personal growth and academic challenges can strengthen applications and clarify a student's individual

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journey.

Choosing Authentic Interests

Students often face pressure to take courses that will impress admissions committees instead of those that genuinely interest them. Admissions offices appreciate students who pursue relevant subjects to their passions and encourage applicants to prioritize meaningful learning experiences. Taking classes that inspire, regardless of their admissions appeal, is vital for personal and academic growth.

Defending Academic Choices

Ultimately, students must advocate for their educational paths, explaining choices that may not align with traditional metrics of success, such as class rank. Admissions committees prefer well-rounded candidates who show both intellectual curiosity and a willingness to explore diverse subjects, indicating that personal fulfillment should take precedence over perceived admissions advantages.

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Example

Key Point:Defending Academic Choices

Example:Throughout the college admissions process, it's essential for you to defend your unique academic choices that resonate with your interests, even if they deviate from traditional metrics of success.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point:Defending Academic Choices

Critical Interpretation:The author posits that students must navigate educational choices with an eye towards personal fulfillment rather than merely pleasing admissions committees. While this is a valid perspective, it raises questions about the complexities of college admissions that extend beyond personal interest, including systemic inequalities in access to quality education that may disadvantage students without resources. It is crucial for readers to consider contrasting viewpoints that emphasize the pragmatics of admissions decisions over individual passions. For example, a report by the National Center for Fair & Open Testing indicates that standardized tests and similar metrics continue to play a significant role in the admissions process, suggesting that focusing solely on personal interests may not always lead to success in college admissions.

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Chapter 6 Summary : Recommendations

Section	Summary
Importance of Recommendations	Recommendations provide insights into a student's character and unique contributions that transcripts do not convey.
The Value of Diverse Perspectives	Endorsements from non-traditional recommenders, like janitors, can enhance an applicant's profile, especially when metrics are similar.
Teacher Recommendations	These letters are crucial in holistic admissions, emphasizing detailed narratives over numerical ratings, focusing on students' qualities.
Characteristics of Effective Recommendations	1. Specificity: Use precise adjectives and anecdotes. 2. Reframing: Redefine strengths based on unique qualities. 3. Novelty: Reveal insights about passions beyond academics.
Building Relationships for Strong Recommendations	Students should build genuine relationships with teachers, ask for recommendations early, and provide updates to aid personalized letters.
Additional Recommendations	Submitting extra recommendations from diverse sources like employers or mentors can offer fresh perspectives, but caution is advised in choosing recommenders.
Conclusion	Successful recommendations provide a deeper view of an applicant's character and stories, strengthening the overall application.

Chapter Seven Summary: Recommendations in College Admissions

Importance of Recommendations

Recommendations play a crucial role in the college admissions process, providing insights beyond academic performance. They can affirm positive character traits and highlight unique contributions of students that transcripts do

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not convey.

The Value of Diverse Perspectives

A particularly impactful recommendation came from a janitor who recognized a student's kindness and engagement. Such endorsements can enhance an applicant's profile when traditional metrics are comparable.

Teacher Recommendations

Teacher recommendations are vital in holistic admissions reviews, which assess a student based on their entire application. These letters typically include a ratings box and a narrative, with admissions officers focusing more on the content of the letters than the numerical ratings. Effective recommendations are those that offer specific details about a student's intellectual and personal qualities.

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Chapter 7 Summary : Extracurriculars

CHAPTER EIGHT: EXTRACURRICULARS

Introduction to Extracurriculars

The author recounts personal experiences with high school extracurricular activities, focusing on the pressures and expectations surrounding them. Despite disliking soccer, the author participated in it for college applications. Other activities, while more enjoyable, were often motivated by the desire to enhance a college résumé.

Key Lessons on Extracurricular Engagement

1.

Engage for Enjoyment

: Students should participate in activities out of genuine interest rather than obligation. High school is a time for exploration.

2.

Allow Time for Teenage Experiences

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: Engaging in non-competitive, personal activities can help students discover their true passions.

3.

Avoid Financial Burden

: Parents and students should focus on low-cost or free ways to get involved in the community.

4.

Authenticity Over Quantity

: Admissions officers prefer genuine interests over superficial achievements.

The Pressure of Competition

The author observes an increasing trend among students to accumulate accolades for college applications, which leads to a rat race of achievements. This obsession causes students to prioritize accomplishments over enjoyment and personal development.

Insights for Admissions Officers

Admissions professionals are more concerned with the impact and authenticity of extracurricular involvement rather than sheer volume of activities. They look for students who

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will contribute meaningfully to the campus community.

Tips for Strengthening Applications

1. Organize activities by significance.
2. Focus on key achievements rather than listing every minor award.
3. Nontraditional activities should also be recognized as valuable.
4. Provide detailed descriptions of activities to highlight their impact.
5. Quality over quantity is key; depth of involvement is more important than a long list of activities.

Conclusion

The author reflects on a student, Lily, who achieved admission to elite colleges but seems unlikely to enjoy free time or personal exploration. This raises concerns about the long-term impact of such an achievement-focused mindset on students' overall well-being and development. The narrative advocates for a balanced approach to extracurriculars: one that fosters personal growth rather than merely fulfilling a checklist for college applications.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The emphasis on genuine engagement in extracurricular activities over mere resume-padding is critical.

Critical Interpretation: In 'Valedictorians at the Gate,' Sabky argues that participating in extracurriculars should be rooted in personal interest and joy rather than solely for enhancing college applications. This perspective encourages students to explore their passions in a meaningful way, contrasting with the prevalent culture of achievement for its own sake. However, one must consider that the author's viewpoint may oversimplify the realities faced by students, who often feel immense pressure to perform and compete. Research from the National Center for Education Statistics indicates a growing trend of students feeling this pressure, suggesting that the context of their choices is complex. Thus, while aiming for authenticity is admirable, the practical realities surrounding college admissions may not allow for such a clear-cut approach.

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Chapter 8 Summary : Testing

CHAPTER NINE: TESTING

The Role of Test Scores in Students' Identities

Students often find their worth and identity reduced to standardized test scores, a practice that seems absurd yet persists. The author reflects on her own experiences with testing, recalling how her SAT score defined her academic worth and comparing it to her husband's indifferent attitude towards his score.

Diverse Perspectives on Testing

In discussions with friends about their test scores, varying opinions emerge. While one friend who performed well questions the validity of standardized tests, another who did not perform as well still sees tests as a necessary evaluation tool. The author finds herself amidst these differing views, acknowledging that while test scores serve as useful data points in admissions, they do not fully represent a student's

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potential.

Flaws in Standardized Testing

Research shows that standardized testing scores can be heavily influenced by socioeconomic factors and race, with wealthier students often outperforming their low-income peers. Despite these disparities, conversations surrounding admissions frequently place undue emphasis on test outcomes.

The Testing Debate in Admissions

The admissions process involves ongoing conversations about the fairness and equity of standardized testing. While such scores aid in standardizing evaluations, they also contribute to the prestige of institutions. Colleges like Dartmouth balance their desire for higher average scores with the knowledge that test scores alone do not define a student's capabilities.

Comprehensive Review of Applications

College admissions at Dartmouth aim for a holistic review

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process, placing test scores in context with other application components. Policies to alleviate testing burdens include accepting late scores and superscoring, recognizing that not all students have equal educational resources.

Challenging the Testing Narrative

The author encounters students who doubt their testing representation and express concerns over their potential. Through dialogue, she emphasizes that exceptional applicants with low scores can still compete if they excel in other academic areas.

Final Thoughts on Standardized Testing

Ultimately, while testing can enhance admissions chances, it is not the defining factor. Each student's unique qualities contribute to their overall application, demonstrating that a person is more than just their test score.

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Example

Key Point: The identity-reducing nature of standardized tests can overshadow true student potential.

Example: Imagine preparing for weeks for a big exam while feeling a sense of dread about how your performance will define you. As you hand in the test, you feel as though your worth hinges entirely on that single score, a feeling shared by your classmates, some of whom see their futures crumble under the weight of a number. Yet, a friend sitting next to you dismissively shrugs off their own score, embodying a carefree attitude toward that same exam. This stark contrast highlights how test scores can erroneously shape identities and influence perceptions, pushing you to recognize that your capabilities extend far beyond standardized measures.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The reduction of students' identities to test scores is challenged by societal and individual factors.

Critical Interpretation: This chapter highlights a critical issue: the prevailing reliance on standardized test scores to gauge a student's worth fundamentally undermines the multifaceted nature of academic potential. While Sabky acknowledges that test scores provide a standardized measure in admissions processes, she emphasizes their inadequacy in capturing a student's holistic capabilities. The disparity in test performance based on socio-economic and racial factors raises significant concerns about the fairness of this practice. Although some may argue that test scores are essential for objective assessments, critics like Paul Tough and his book 'How Children Succeed' argue that non-cognitive skills, resilience, and character traits are vital for success, suggesting that standardized testing should not dominate educational evaluations.

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Chapter 9 Summary : The Personal Statement

THE PERSONAL STATEMENT

Introduction to Personal Statements

After completing recommendations and testing, students are tasked with writing their personal statements. This essay should reflect on personal challenges and focus on authenticity rather than seeking shock value or using ornate vocabulary.

Key Insights on Crafting an Essay

-

Essence of Personalization

: The main secret to a great statement is keeping it personal and making a clear point about one's individuality.

-

Memorable Essays

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: The author recalls only a few standout essays among thousands read, emphasizing that most successful essays simply convey information about the applicant.

Advice for Writing

1.

Be Specific

: Focus on a single moment rather than broad summaries; detailed anecdotes are more impactful.

2.

Self-Focus

: Avoid writing about heroes or influential figures. Instead, share unique personal stories and experiences.

3.

Uniqueness

: Each essay should be distinctly reflective of the writer's life: it should be identifiable amidst a sea of submissions.

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Chapter 10 Summary : Supplemental Essays

CHAPTER ELEVEN: SUPPLEMENTAL ESSAYS

Overview of Supplemental Essays

Many colleges require supplemental essays in addition to personal statements during the application process. These essays often provide more authentic insights into applicants compared to personal statements, which are usually better edited.

Types of Supplemental Questions

Colleges tailor their supplemental questions, which can range from short answers of about 200 words to multiple longer responses. Some institutions may also accept various other written or multimedia submissions.

Student Attitudes and Challenges

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Many students find supplemental essays burdensome, expressing frustration over additional writing requirements. Questions about personal preferences or weaknesses often feel trivial or overly challenging.

Purpose and Value of Supplemental Essays

Despite the challenges they pose, supplemental essays allow students to provide more personal details beyond grades and scores. They serve as valuable opportunities to enhance one's application, especially when reflecting on specific activities or experiences.

Examples of Effective Responses

The text emphasizes crafting meaningful responses. Instead of generic statements (like "Soccer teaches me teamwork"), applicants are encouraged to provide concrete examples that reveal their personality and experience.

Common Types of Questions

Colleges ask a variety of questions, categorized as:

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- Something about the applicant (e.g., recent changes of opinion)
- Something about the college (e.g., suggestions for guest speakers)
- Icebreakers (e.g., favorite songs)

Importance of Specificity

Admissions officers seek detailed, genuine responses. The specificity of answers demonstrates an applicant's thoughtfulness and genuine interest in the college.

Marketing and Institutional Insights

Supplemental questions serve as marketing tools for colleges, allowing them to highlight their strengths and connect with applicants on a more personal level.

Final Thoughts

Strong personal statements are essential, but equally significant is the effort put into supplemental essays. Effective supplements can reveal personality, seriousness, and interest in a school, ultimately strengthening an application.

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Chapter 11 Summary : Submitting the Application

CHAPTER TWELVE: SUBMITTING THE APPLICATION

Overview of the Admissions Process

Colleges admit students based on their needs for a specific class, focusing on the overall candidacy rather than minor errors. Students must dedicate time to the application and ensure they effectively showcase their strengths through all components.

Application Structure

A standard college application consists of ten sections:

1. Personal Details
2. Extracurriculars/Honors
3. Personal Statement
4. Supplemental Essays

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5. (Optional) Arts Supplement
6. Testing
7. School Transcript/High School Profile
8. Counselor Recommendation
9. Teacher Recommendations
10. (Optional) Alumni Interview Report

Admissions officers spend an average of twelve minutes reviewing applications, emphasizing the importance of thorough and detailed submissions.

Key Advice for Applicants

1.

Strategize the Application Process

Students should view the application as a puzzle, focusing on how various components highlight their strengths.

Aligning personal statements and supplemental questions with strengths is crucial for a cohesive narrative.

2.

Be Detailed and Descriptive

Specific answers that fully utilize the “Additional Information” section can enhance an application. This

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section is an opportunity to convey unique experiences, backgrounds, and perspectives that might not be covered elsewhere.

3.

Attention to Detail Matters

Small details can say much about a student's character. Application sections must be filled out meticulously, as carelessness, even with trivial information like an email address, can impact the admissions decision.

The Role of Online Presence

Students should be mindful of their social media profiles. While not routinely checked, a positive or negative online presence can affect admissions decisions.

Common Pitfalls in Applications

Many students submit standard applications lacking depth. Providing additional context, insights into personal experiences, and thoroughness can transform a flat application into a standout one.

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Conclusion

The college application process is a critical first step in self-marketing for students. It should be approached with careful consideration of every detail to avoid regrets and missed opportunities. An application that reflects an applicant's true essence, with no juvenile oversights, is vital for showcasing their candidacy effectively.

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Chapter 12 Summary : Alumni Interviews

Chapter 13: Alumni Interviews

Overview of Alumni Interviews

After submitting applications, many college-bound students face the final hurdle of interviews, which can be conducted by admissions officers, current students, or alumni. Alumni interviews are particularly common at highly selective colleges, serving to assist in the admissions process.

Interview Policies and Procedures

- Interviews occur only after an application is deemed complete.
- Most alumni interviews take place in public settings for safety reasons.
- Availability of alumni interviewers can vary by location, and not all applicants are guaranteed an interview.

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Importance of the Interview

The interview process offers students a chance to present their personalities beyond the paper application. Through interviews, students can confirm details, expand on their passions, and showcase their humanity.

Alumni Interview Experience

Most alumni interviewers tend to recommend their interviewees, leading to positive experiences for both parties. However, instances of unremarkable interviews can stand out more significantly in the admissions process.

Perception and Impact of Interviews

The perceived value of interviews can differ among alumni.

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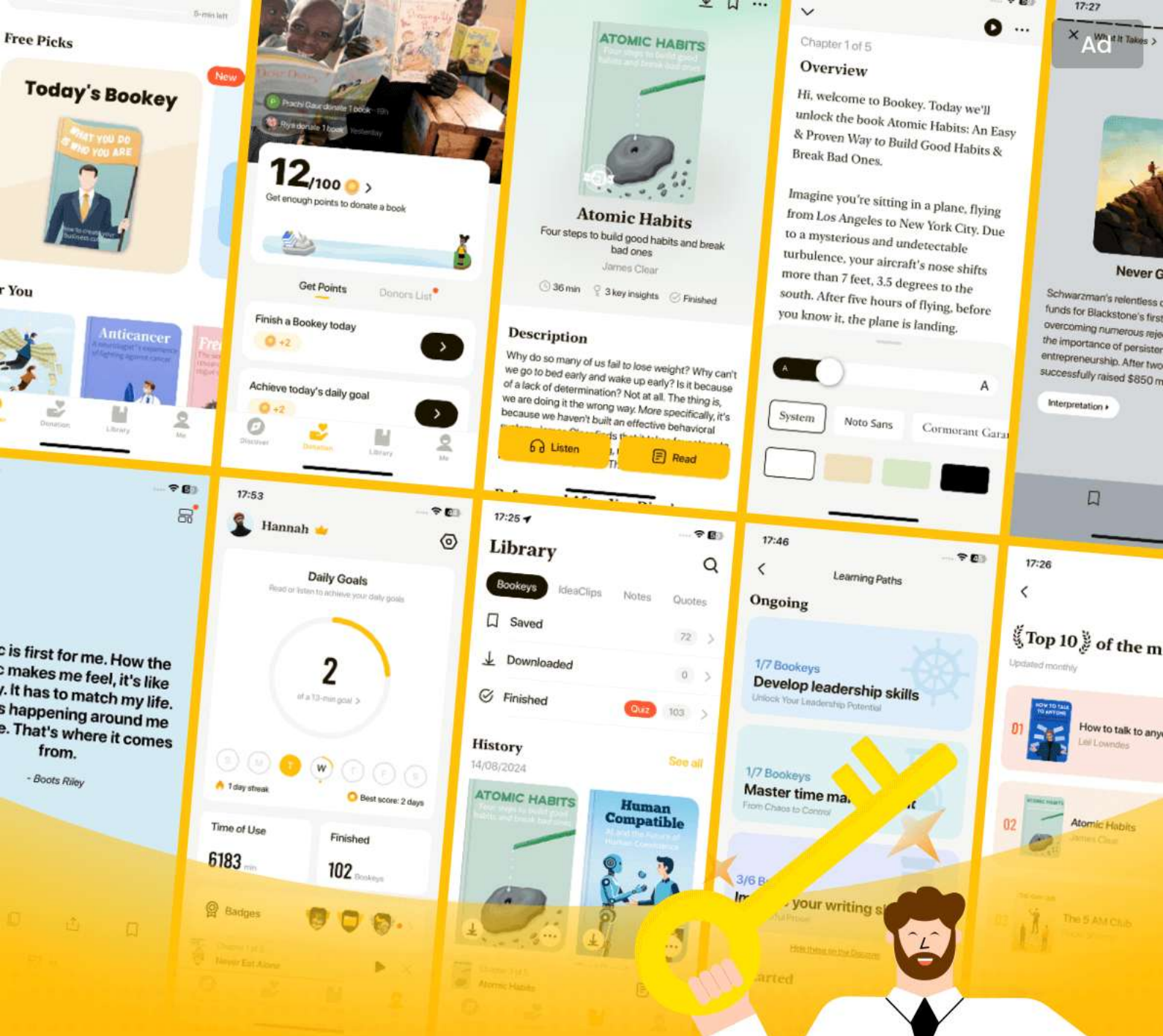
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Chapter 13 Summary : A Word on Early

A WORD ON EARLY APPLICATIONS

Introduction to Early Applications

Students often view early applications to colleges, particularly Dartmouth, as a mark of achievement and planning, believing it enhances their acceptance chances. Though many still opt for regular decision, early applicants statistically experience better odds, even after accounting for recruited athletes.

The Context of Early Applications

Controversy surrounds early application programs as they can skew admission rates. Colleges may rely on these programs to manage their admissions statistics, leading to concerns about fairness for students from less-resourced schools.

Types of Early Application Programs

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Early Decision (ED)

: A binding commitment to attend if admitted, potentially offering a stronger statistical advantage.

-

Early Action (EA)

: A non-binding option that allows students to receive decisions earlier without the obligation to matriculate.

Advantages of Early Programs

- Earlier peace of mind regarding college acceptance.
- Competitive odds at selective institutions.

Disadvantages of Early Programs

1. Financial Aid Limitations: ED applicants cannot compare financial aid offers from different schools.
2. Strength of Application: Late bloomers may lack senior midyear grades, which could strengthen their application.
3. Premature Commitment: Students may feel pressured to choose a preference without thorough consideration.

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Considerations for Deferred Applicants

Deferred students will have their applications reviewed in the regular pool, and must proactively communicate updates on their achievements.

Final Thoughts

Students should carefully evaluate the benefits and drawbacks of applying early, and colleges must strive to ensure equitable access to early application opportunities. The perception of early programs as advantageous must be balanced against the pressures they can impose.

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Chapter 14 Summary : International Applicants

International Applicants

This chapter discusses the complexities faced by international applicants applying to U.S. colleges, particularly at Dartmouth. The author shares insights from their experience as the director of international admissions, highlighting the benefits of having international students on campus and the unique challenges they face during the application process.

Key Considerations for International Admissions Process

1.

Definition of an International Applicant

Colleges define international applicants as those who do not possess a U.S. passport. Permanent residents and undocumented students are treated differently in the

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admissions process.

2.

Impact of Financial Aid on Admissions

Most U.S. colleges, including Dartmouth, are need-aware for international students, meaning financial aid needs are considered during admissions decisions. As a result, institutions often favor wealthier, full-pay applicants due to limited financial aid resources.

Competitive Nature of International Admissions

The admissions process is significantly more competitive for international students, with an acceptance rate of about 2% at Dartmouth. The diversity of the international applicant pool is essential, as each applicant brings unique cultural backgrounds and experiences.

Recruitment Insights

The author reflects on their recruitment travels across various countries, emphasizing the importance of understanding local educational systems and expectations. They note the difference in how universities are perceived abroad and the

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pressure to maintain a diverse applicant pool from different nations.

Advice for International Applicants

1.

Provide Context

: Students should explain their school's curriculum and extracurricular offerings to give admissions officers a clearer understanding of their backgrounds.

2.

Consider Recommendations

: Recommendations can come from various sources, not just traditional school counselors, adapting to the international context.

3.

Be Prepared for Testing

: International applicants are advised to be organized with testing requirements, including English-language proficiency tests, to demonstrate their readiness for college-level work.

Beyond Citizenship

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The chapter highlights the desire of international students to be seen as individuals rather than merely representatives of their countries. While colleges aim to enhance diversity, they also acknowledge the complexity of each student's story and the importance of looking beyond just citizenship and financial status.

Conclusion

International students are valued members of the college community, contributing to its richness and diversity. They must navigate unique challenges in the admissions process, but with careful preparation and advocacy, they can present compelling applications that reflect their true selves and potential.

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Chapter 15 Summary : Recruited Athletes

RECRUITED ATHLETES

Overview of the Admissions Process for Athletes

The chapter discusses the unique process of admissions for recruited athletes at Dartmouth. Each recruit undergoes an academic prereview to ensure they meet the Ivy League's Academic Index (AI). Coaches provide early feedback on recruits' applications, and much time is spent ensuring that athletic applications receive thorough examination.

Three Key Aspects of the Admissions Process

1.

Academic Prereview

: Athletes must meet AI standards based on GPA and test scores, although the AI calculation has its flaws and doesn't account for the strength of coursework.

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2.

Early Feedback

: Coaches receive early admissions feedback on recruits, which helps streamline the recruitment process. Positive early feedback often leads to eventual admission.

3.

Role of Coaches

: Coaches are the primary point of contact for recruits during admissions, while admissions officers remain limited in direct communication with athletes and their families.

Challenges with Athletic Admissions

While many recruits have strong academic records, issues can arise when athletic prowess comes with underwhelming academic performance. Admissions officers sometimes push back against pressures from coaches regarding athletes who appear academically unprepared.

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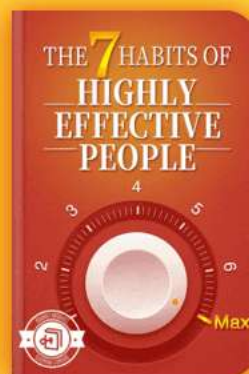
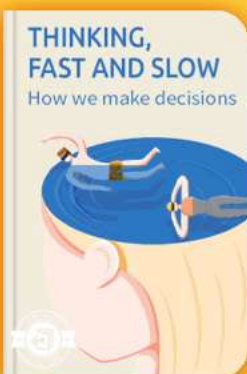


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Chapter 16 Summary : Decision Day

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN: DECISION DAY

Emotional Responses from Students

Decision day elicits a range of emotions from students, including gratitude, disappointment, and the tensions of being waitlisted. The admissions office often receives calls from students reacting to their decisions, with the most common scenario being inquiries from waitlisted students about how to stand out.

Challenges of Handling Rejections

Rejection calls, particularly from parents, can be challenging for admissions officers. Parents often struggle to accept their child's rejection, leading to confrontational calls. Admissions representatives are trained to remain polite and provide general responses while making it clear that decisions are final and cannot be changed based on emotional pleas.

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Normalizing Rejection

To help students cope with rejection, normalizing the experience is vital. Sharing personal rejection stories or creating supportive environments, such as a "Rejection Wall" at schools, can lessen the sting. Students are encouraged to express their emotions, seek support, and eventually pivot towards new opportunities.

The Waitlist Process

Wait-listed students are still in the running for admission and are encouraged to remain engaged. Only active students who confirm their interest will be considered, and maintaining strong academic performance is crucial. Communication with admissions officers can also enhance the chances of being admitted from the waitlist.

Changing Perspectives on Admissions

There is a notion among some students that rejection diminishes their achievements. Admissions officers face a similar sentiment among students who were accepted but continue to lament about schools they didn't get into. It is

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important to recognize that every college offers unique opportunities, and students should remain open to all possibilities.

Conclusion: Value in Every Admission

Ultimately, receiving an acceptance from any college is a significant achievement. The narrative of competition and prestige should not overshadow individual accomplishments or the value of attending schools like Colby College, which may not carry the same name recognition but offer equally rewarding experiences.

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Chapter 17 Summary : Admitted Student Events

Admitted Student Events

Overview of Decision Timeline

Regular decision admits face a tight deadline to select a college, with admissions notifications typically sent in late March and a May 1 deadline for intent to enroll. April is a hectic month for students visiting colleges and weighing their options.

Experiences During Admitted Student Events

The author describes her role during the admitted student events at Dartmouth, engaging with prospective students and their families. An exchange with a student, Carla, highlights the unique and personal factors influencing college choice, such as the ability to keep pets like goldfish.

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Factors Influencing College Decisions

The decision-making process is deeply personal and varies by individual priorities, including job security, financial considerations, sports opportunities, and personal connections. The author emphasizes that every student has valid reasons for their choices, including personal preferences and serendipity.

Visit Experiences and Engagement

The chapter narrates experiences of both the author and other students during campus visits, illustrating that the environment and individuals encountered can significantly affect perceptions. Often, students may later realize that their initial impressions might not reflect the true nature of a college.

The Role of Admissions Offices

During April, admissions teams work tirelessly to attract admitted students through campus events designed to showcase the college's strengths. These experiences can include both on-campus and off-campus events hosted by

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alumni, aimed at forging connections with prospective students.

Recommendations for Admitted Students

The author encourages students to take ownership of their decision-making process. Such strategies include:

1.

Speak Up

: Report any unsatisfactory experiences during visits for better matches and engagement.

2.

Appeal Financial Aid

: Request reevaluation of offers if needed, as many colleges can be flexible with financial assistance.

3.

Ask for Extensions

: Inquire about extending the enrollment deadline for personal or logistical reasons.

Final Thoughts on College Choice

Despite the pressures surrounding college decisions, the author reassures that no single college can be deemed 'right'

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for everyone. She advises students to choose thoughtfully, recognizing that a variety of excellent institutions are available to them, and to approach their selected choice with enthusiasm and commitment.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Personal Factors in College Decision-Making

Critical Interpretation: In her summary, the author emphasizes the significance of individual priorities such as financial stability, job security, and personal connections in the college choice process. While recognizing that these considerations are valid and deeply personal, it's vital to question whether such subjective emphasis may inadvertently downplay other equally important factors like academic program strength or institutional culture. The perspective that each student has unique reasons for their college selection can overshadow the role of an institution's long-term value, potentially leading students to make decisions based solely on immediate or personal preferences. Critically, the tendency for institutions to market themselves based on emotional and personal appeals raises concerns about the authenticity of choices made. Scholars like Bessie D. M. Chiu and Julie M. K. O'Rourke discuss the complexities surrounding college decisions in "The College Decision-Making Process" (Higher Education Review, Vol. 15), highlighting that

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rational factors often intertwine with personal motivations, suggesting that students should balance emotional considerations with pragmatic evaluations.

Chapter 18 Summary : Welcome to College

Chapter 19: Welcome to College

Personal Reflection on Cheerleading Experience

The author reflects on her middle school cheerleading experience, where despite lacking skills like performing a back handspring, her enthusiasm helped her earn a spot on the varsity team. Initially elated, she soon realized her role as a base in team formations, learning that being chosen does not equate to superiority or inferiority, but rather being the right fit at the right time.

Transition to College Life

The author observes new first-year students at Dartmouth during orientation, noting their nervousness and excitement. She emphasizes that while these students were selected from a competitive applicant pool, their acceptance doesn't

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inherently make them better than those who were rejected. The author highlights the privilege of attending such a prestigious institution and the importance of maximizing this opportunity.

Admissions Perspective

Through interactions with students and parents, the author clarifies her role as an admissions officer, explaining that decisions are based on what the college seeks in a cohort rather than a notion of deserving. Each student has unique strengths, and college admissions is about fitting these students into a larger vision for the institution.

Encouragement for Student Engagement

The author encourages students to embrace their college experience fully, emphasizing the importance of participation

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Chapter 19 Summary : Best in Class

CHAPTER TWENTY: BEST IN CLASS

Labor and College Connections

The author reflects on her experience in labor at Dartmouth-Hitchcock Medical Center, where she paradoxically found herself immersed in college discussions with hospital staff, a reminder of her connection to academia even during a significant life event. Her son, Rudy, is born in good health, and the author celebrates his arrival amidst the joys of new motherhood and the overwhelming congratulatory messages from friends and family.

Reflections on College Admissions

A few months after Rudy's birth, the author resigns from her role at Dartmouth's admissions office, feeling liberated to engage with families about various college options without restrictions. She expresses her frustrations with the competitive nature of college admissions, where students are

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driven to enhance their resumes, often at the expense of their authenticity and well-being. The author calls for a reevaluation of what “impressiveness” means in the context of college applications.

The Valedictorian Event

The author describes a tiring admissions event where prospective students focus on presenting their best selves, while she observes their behaviors as somewhat robotic. A moment of connection arises when she encounters a valet named Ernie, who takes the time to save a frog, contrasting the frenetic energy surrounding college applications. This interaction prompts the author to consider significant qualities beyond mere achievements.

Critique of the Admissions Process

The narrative critiques the complex nature of college admissions, emphasizing the need for greater transparency and fairness. The author suggests that colleges should diversify representation on admissions committees and stop prioritizing legacy admissions. She shares her desire to shift focus away from rankings and encourages students to

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prioritize genuine personal development over creating an impressive façade.

Parenthood and Redefining Success

As the author transitions into motherhood, she reflects on the lessons acquired throughout her career in admissions. She hopes for her children to develop character and decency rather than simply chasing prestigious college degrees. Emphasizing the importance of kindness over credentials, she envisions raising children who appreciate the humanity in others, endorsing the idea that being decent is far more important than merely being smart or successful in the traditional sense.

Conclusion: The Value of Decency

The author concludes with a powerful message that while achieving good grades is valuable, being a good person is what truly impresses. She advocates for cultivating well-rounded individuals who prioritize kindness, community, and responsibility, ultimately encouraging students to be both academically successful and morally upright.

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Chapter 20 Summary : Notes 4

Chapter 20: The Campus Visit

Overview of Student Interests

1. College fairs reveal many students aspire to careers such as CSI investigators.

Fly-In Programs

2. Fly-In programs allow underprivileged students to visit campuses, hosted by schools like Dartmouth.

Challenges of Demonstrated Interest

3. Demonstrated interest is problematic as it unfairly favors students with more resources.

Admissions Center Experience

4. A failed environmental project in the admissions center

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showcased poor resource use despite good intentions.

5. The Dartmouth lobby contrasts with more inviting admissions lobbies, like that of St. Lawrence University.

6. The office eventually modernized its furniture for a better visitor experience.

Dartmouth Legacies

7. Dartmouth is notable for the invention of the BASIC programming language in 1964.

8. Colby College mirrors Dartmouth's library architecture.

New Hampshire Weather

9. New Hampshire's cold climate becomes evident by January as students experience frost forming on their noses.

Admission Essays

10. A 2019 supplemental question for Dartmouth reflects on the school's unique appeal and its historical significance.

Campus Culture

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11. The author values informal listening opportunities around campus to gain insights.

12. Dr. Seuss, a distinguished Dartmouth alum, is frequently referenced within the college community.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The bias in admissions processes

Critical Interpretation: One key point in Chapter 20 concerns the inequity present in college admissions, particularly regarding the concept of demonstrated interest. The author argues that demonstrated interest can advantage students with greater financial resources, as these students can afford to visit campuses and participate in related programs. This perspective prompts readers to critically examine the admissions landscape and recognize that the criteria used to assess student interest may perpetuate socioeconomic disparities. While the author presents valid concerns, it is essential to remember that other factors can also play a significant role in admissions, and frameworks like holistic review processes are aimed at providing a more equitable evaluation (source: Aiken, M. L. "College Admissions: Overview of Criteria and Equity Issues", Journal of Higher Education Policy).

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Chapter 21 Summary : Notes 6

Chapter Summary: The School Report

Public vs. Private School Counselors

Approximately 90 percent of American high school students attended public schools in 2015. Many public school counselors, despite being well-intentioned, seemed overwhelmed and unable to provide extensive support for students, unlike private school counselors who could dedicate more time.

Inspiration from Teachers

A teacher who was known for strict grading inspired the author to pursue writing, emphasizing the importance of attention to detail in language.

Call for Change

The author acknowledges the inequities present in the

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education system and encourages initiatives for change.

Classroom Experiences

The author reflects on the diverse and sometimes unconventional classes available in schools.

Support for the Arts

Discussions in admissions offices highlight the importance of maintaining support for the arts amid budget cuts to these programs.

Pride in Diverse Experiences

The author expresses a wish to have communicated their pride in attending a public high school, valuing the diverse experiences gained from commuting with a variety of students, and shared learning moments with a sibling.

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Chapter 22 Summary : Notes 17

Chapter Seventeen: Decision Day

Personal Touch in Admissions

- Handwritten notes were occasionally added to admit letters to personalize communication with incoming students, inviting them to campus.

Handling Mistaken Applications

- Unique cases of mistaken materials in applications were revisited, a rare occurrence in the admissions process.

Inspiration from Other Industries

- The admissions approach was influenced by practices from the cable industry.

Gap Year Significance

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- Gap years, which allow students to work, travel, or volunteer before college, are becoming increasingly popular, providing valuable maturity and direction.

Wait List Statistics

- Dartmouth's wait list acceptance is very low, with under 10% of applicants offered a place.

Choosing a Major

- Typically, a student's chosen major wasn't critical unless on the wait list. Honesty about intended majors was advised.

Costly Miscommunication

- Interest in admission could have been communicated more simply via email, potentially saving costs for students.

Class Status Communication

- The status of the incoming class wasn't disclosed until it was finalized, typically by mid-May.

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Applying to Multiple Ivies

- Applying to all eight Ivy League schools seemed elitist and puzzling due to their distinct differences.

Donations and Personal Gains

- There was a struggle to donate small gift cards received at college fairs, highlighting a conflict between personal benefit and professional expectations.

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Chapter 23 Summary : Notes 19

Chapter Nineteen: Welcome to College

Main Experiences

1. Encounter with Celebrity: My husband once asked Scarlett Johansson on a date, believing she had to say yes to someone.
2. Encouragement to Participate: Students who didn't engage in activities received calls from upperclassmen to motivate them.
3. Nerves Before College: I spent the night before college anxiously in a Holiday Inn bathroom while my family was preoccupied. However, arriving at my dorm with friendly roommates eased my nerves.

Social Observations

4. Graduation Party Dichotomy: Throughout college, I received only one invitation to a graduation party, contrasting the frequent invites to high school senior plays.

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5. Regrets in Speech: I once welcomed international students as “the best and brightest,” a phrase I now reconsider.

Traditions and Commitment

6. Homecoming Tradition: Participating in a bonfire run was an exhilarating first-year ritual.

7. Dedication to Classes: My husband hardly missed a class during his four years, making sure to attend regardless of his conditions, as viewed through the lens of his financial commitment.

Post-College Reflections

8. Life After Graduation: After graduation, my husband’s job lacked social activities, leading him to reminisce about the college days filled with fun and games.

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Chapter 1 | Quotes From Pages 39-58

1. A student needs to consider why (or why not) he should go to college.
2. I believe the race to college should be more of a thoughtful stroll.
3. The most important thing you can do to prepare for college is to go to high school.
4. They should learn for the sake of learning.
5. What a student takes out of high school is what she will bring to college.

Chapter 2 | Quotes From Pages 59-67

1. Get excited about more than one school. Applying to college isn't marriage. A student can fall in love (or at least like) with multiple schools.
2. Use a college's average standardized testing data and its

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admissions rate as an admissions probability guide.

3. Apply only to colleges one wants to attend. I've never liked the term 'safety school.' Nobody bubbles over with excitement about a safety choice.
4. Every college in America has the potential to change a student's life.
5. I hope they care more about personal opportunity than rankings.

Chapter 3 | Quotes From Pages 68-84

1. A visit to campus captures the spirit of the college in a way unlike any brochure or university marketing campaign can.
2. I encourage ALL students to do the following before applying to a college.
3. In my opinion, the dining hall is a 'must see' on campus but not for reasons one would imagine.
4. This is a chance to turn over a few rocks, peek backstage, and take a test-drive of an institution.
5. Many college campuses look similar. Many admissions

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officers sound the same. Many universities seem interchangeable.

6.What mattered more than my opinion on these young people was their own initiative for leaving no stone unturned.

7.For those who couldn't visit, a supplemental essay could still be specific if he researched (or engaged with) a department, club, or community on a deeper level.

8.College is an investment.

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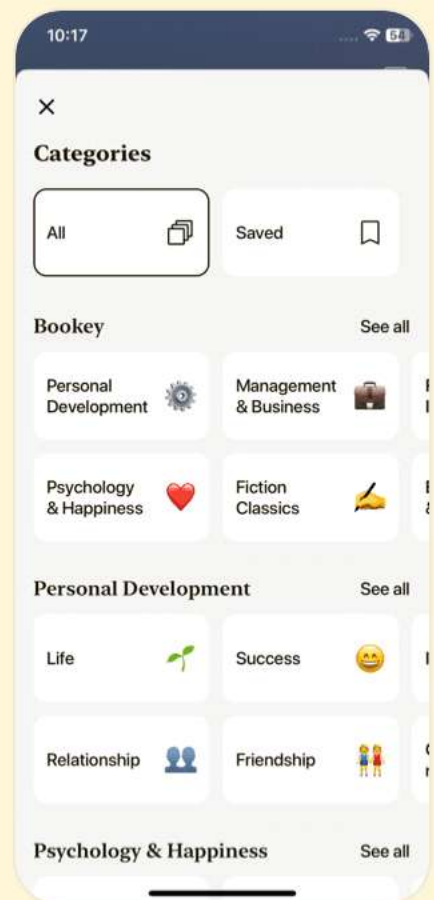
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Chapter 4 | Quotes From Pages 85-104

1. When the bell rang, the young men immediately packed up their backpacks with an urgency to go somewhere. But Layla lingered, clearly wanting to learn more.
2. I enjoyed meeting them, walking their school hallways, and recruiting them to apply.
3. Instead, I was taken with the way the person acted among his peers, respected his community, and treated others.
4. There's always time for reading," she corrected him before turning to me. "Don't worry about it. I was just curious.
5. You know a lot of characters.
6. The most impressive students I met on the road: 1. Led with their person, not their accolades.
7. But the truth was that I didn't see it often. The students I remembered sometimes weren't memorable for the right reasons.
8. Layla is the most memorable. But she's also the one that got away.



Chapter 5 | Quotes From Pages 107-128

1. A student's schooling and curriculum decisions (if lucky enough to choose) shouldn't be based on what "looks good" to a committee, but rather what "is good" for him.
2. Students shouldn't make excuses, but they should make their case.
3. A person's experience in high school shouldn't just be about college admissions probability.
4. The point is to make the most of any opportunity to learn, to grow, to mature.
5. Every student can compete in the admissions process, regardless of where one goes to high school.

Chapter 6 | Quotes From Pages 129-146

1. A letter of recommendation matters in the college admissions process. It can confirm that the valedictorian isn't a narcissist. It can argue that the student with a B+ in French is more intellectually curious than another student with an

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A.

2. But the greatest and most helpful recommendation I read was written by a member of a school's custodial staff. The janitor had volunteered to write the letter on behalf of the applicant because that student was the only young person who had ever bothered to learn his name.
3. What made a good recommendation was the same thing that made a great essay, a great interview, a great application: an insight into an applicant's humanity.
4. It's great to be a good student. It's wonderful to impress one's teachers. But it's even better to give them something to talk about.
5. The student who tinkered with jewelry on the way to school. The student who is the teacher's first choice as a bus mate on a school trip.

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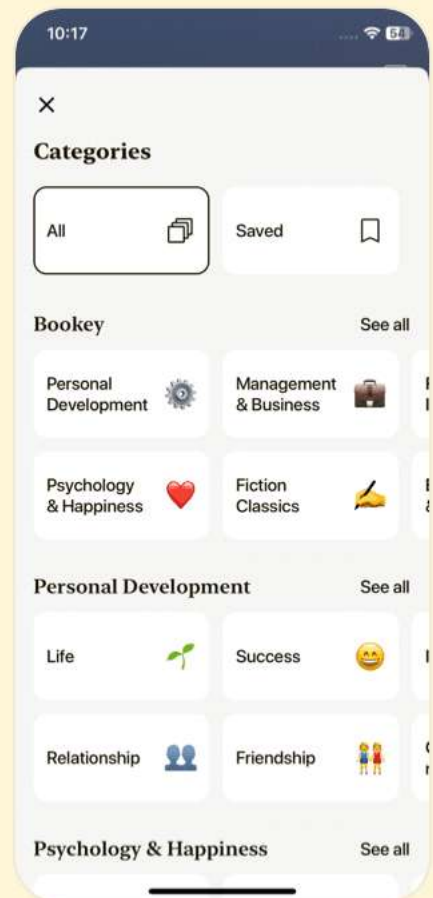
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Chapter 7 | Quotes From Pages 147-164

1. High school is the time to experiment, join, quit, retry, and show up.
2. If a student didn't allow himself time for activities that didn't 'count,' he might never discover his true passions.
3. A student needs to be doing something, but he doesn't need to be doing everything.
4. Depth (and enthusiasm) over breadth is essential.
5. Extracurricular interests matter because they shape a person, not because they strengthen a résumé.
6. Students who participate in activities because they're interested might just become more interesting.
7. She looked much happier in the photo than she had looked in person.

Chapter 8 | Quotes From Pages 165-184

1. No perfect score has an admissions guarantee. No imperfect score has a denial guarantee.
2. While folks are obsessing, remembering, forgetting, and dismissing their standardized test scores, the one thing I

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know for sure is that a person is more than her number.

3. You shouldn't let your scores dictate an otherwise exceptional application.
4. The greater distance traveled to college access, the more lenient colleges often were with scores.
5. Savvy students generally know if their applications will be competitive in a university's pool... But there were students who didn't apply because they didn't know that they did belong in the pool.

Chapter 9 | Quotes From Pages 185-198

1. The number one secret to writing a great personal statement is, at the risk of being obvious, to keep it personal and make a statement.
2. An essay about winning a school debate tournament isn't specific enough. An essay about being nervous before a school debate tournament isn't specific enough. But an essay about using one's debate skills to single-handedly challenge the superintendent to allow a local Vietnamese food truck driver to park (and serve) on school grounds

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might just make the grade.

3.Laurie's story was her own. Other applicants need to consider their stories, their quirks, their motivations, their habits.

4.The admissions process isn't meant to be an essay contest.

5.We all have something to say.

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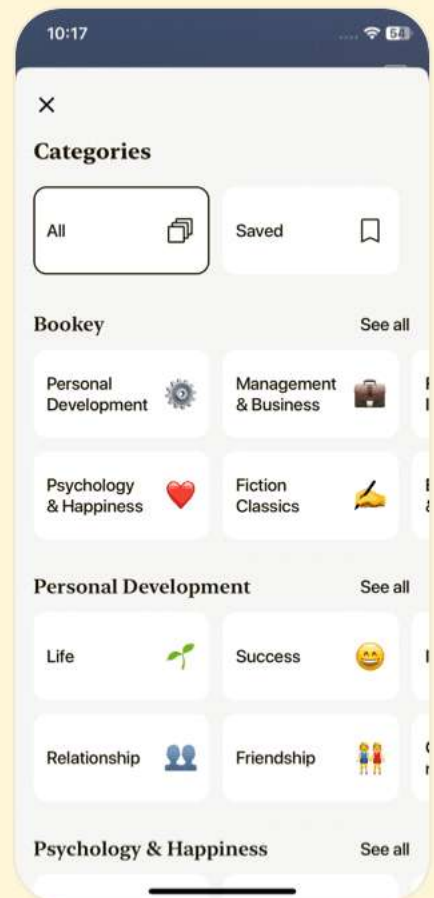
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Chapter 10 | Quotes From Pages 199-205

1. Supplemental essays often felt rushed, half answered, or poorly written.
2. The supplements gave students another opportunity to share details other than grades or scores.
3. If the essay was the heart of an application, the supplement was its soul.
4.many colleges ask applicants on the supplement to elaborate on an activity of significance.
5.supplemental questions to make the process feel more personal.

Chapter 11 | Quotes From Pages 206-220

1. Colleges are going to admit the students that they need in a class. One spelling error is not going to change an admissions officer's decision.
2. Students (hopefully) were spending more than twelve minutes on their applications.
3. A strong application presents the reader with specific answers to all relevant questions.



4. Something as seemingly trivial as the 'family information section' can help to confirm one student's first-generation status or another student's legacy connections.
5. The students who capitalized on the most 'minor' things made their applications more dynamic.
6. There should be no regrets. There should be no missed opportunities. There should be no 'if onlys.'

Chapter 12 | Quotes From Pages 221-235

1. Interviews confirmed what was already mentioned in the application.
2. Interviews allowed students to expand on application information.
3. Interviews allowed students to be human.
4. An outstanding interview made an applicant a little harder to deny.
5. Positivity breeds positivity.

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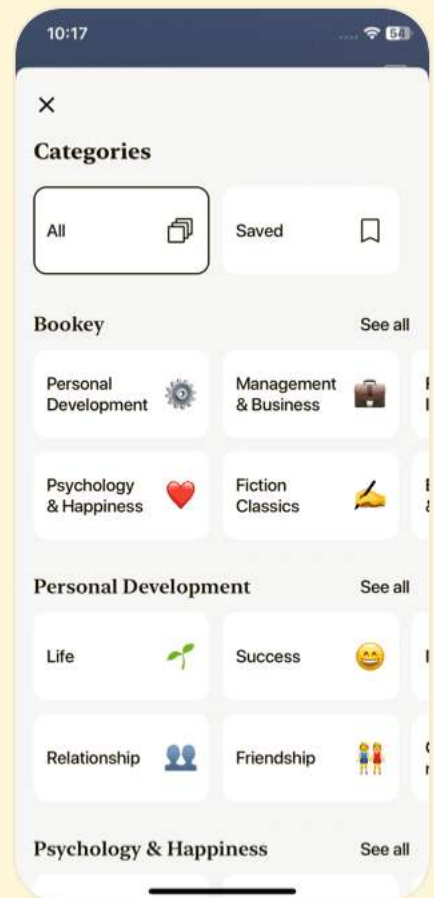
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Chapter 13 | Quotes From Pages 238-245

1. Applying early is their badge of honor, a reflection of their organizational skills and their commitment to the college.
2. I never understood the pros and cons of early programs until I worked in the admissions office.
3. There can be real issues with applying early... binding early programs only allow a student to consider one institution's financial aid package.
4. Plus, I witnessed some early decision students who fell victim to 'senioritis'... putting less effort into one's schoolwork after being admitted.
5. Early programs have their perks. But they also provide their pressures.

Chapter 14 | Quotes From Pages 246-260

1. International students, while highly valued by the college community, would still be a minority of the class.
2. At the end of the day, our young people wanted to be

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valued for their individual perspectives and not just the perspectives of the boxes they checked in an admissions report.

- 3.The best an international student can do is be realistic about his ability to pay tuition when filling out admissions and financial aid forms.
- 4.Colleges wanted to increase the number of foreign citizens in their school profiles.
- 5.Yet most colleges are committed to achieving socioeconomic diversity within their international pools, so they do their best to stretch their dollars.

Chapter 15 | Quotes From Pages 261-277

- 1.I believe in college athletics. I also believe that anyone with privilege in the admissions process should at least make one's best effort.
- 2.Doing more when one could do less showed one's character.
- 3.The most important advice I gave recruited student athletes was to be a student first when it came to the application.

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4. There is decency in giving a damn about a personal statement.

5. Athletes might impress folks on the field, but they weren't going to gain the admiration of fellow students unless they pulled their weight on the boat AND in the classroom.

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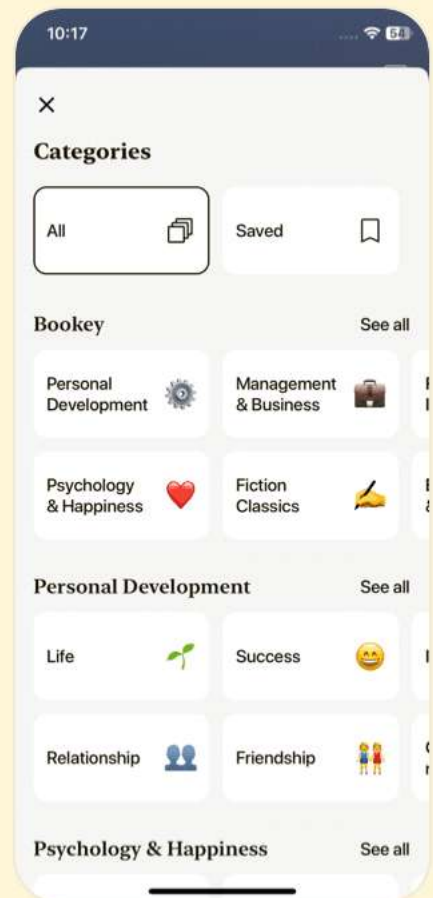
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Chapter 16 | Quotes From Pages 280-301

- 1.Rejection happens. And in competitive college admissions, most are victims of the numbers.
- 2.But after the rejection, there's no choice but to move along to an opened gate rather than clinging to one that is closed.
- 3.There are great colleges out there... But Dartmouth is where I belong.
- 4.It seemed that many students were stationed somewhere in the college food chain, and some weren't happy unless they had access to the full buffet.
- 5.The business of competitive college admission was built on the rejection majority. And to my knowledge, I never met a rejected Dartmouth applicant who was not admitted somewhere.

Chapter 17 | Quotes From Pages 302-313

- 1.You should go to the school that makes the most sense.
- 2.If they both make sense, either will work out.
- 3.Their decisions were their own.

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4. Most students would similarly learn, grow, and spread their wings at more than one institution.

5. There is no one 'right' college. There are many.

6. Choose one. Move forward. And make it count.

Chapter 18 | Quotes From Pages 314-330

1. Sometimes you'll be chosen. Other times you won't. Often the choice will be for unknown reasons. But being chosen doesn't mean you're better than anyone else. It doesn't mean you're worse. It just means that you were the right person at the right time, and you'd best make the most of the opportunity.

2. I wanted students to have fun. But I also wanted them to go to every class. I wanted them to join the clubs, kick the balls, do the things. I wanted them to visit the organic farm because they could. I wanted them to stop worrying about checked boxes and start worrying about missed opportunities.

3. No matter the ranking of the school, no matter the color of

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the sweatshirt, no matter the location, colleges were working hard to offer a student the chance to grow. The investment in these young people was not to be wasted.

4.They were still themselves, chock-full of strengths, weaknesses, and everything in between. I hoped students would celebrate their college picks.

5.I wanted them to recognize the investment made by the college. As an admissions officer, I knew how equally special the students were who were rejected from Dartmouth. I knew the poetry talent of the denied and the extracurricular talents of those who never escaped the wait list.

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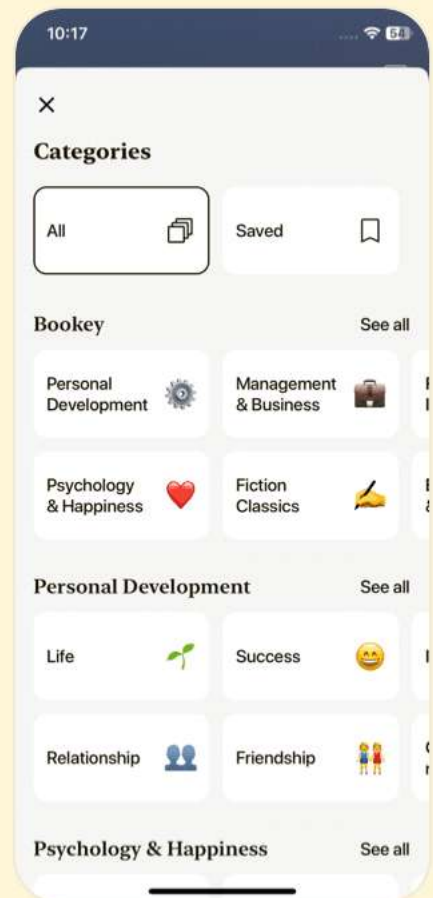
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Chapter 19 | Quotes From Pages 331-343

1. A person was much more than his numbers.
2. In fact, I was really impressed. Nobody else stopped for the poor creature.
3. The most impressive young people I met hung their hats on their decency, not on the brand names of their diplomas.
4. I want to raise a kid who stands out for the right reasons.
The kid who cares more about kindness than clout.
5. Being smart is valued. But being decent is impressive.

Chapter 20 | Quotes From Pages 359-362

1. It is, Sir ... a small college. And yet, there are those who love it!
2. Less-resourced students don't have the same opportunities to prove their commitment.
3. I'm a strong advocate for eavesdropping in the dining hall.

Chapter 21 | Quotes From Pages 365-367

1. One of my teachers inspired me to become a writer.
2. Nope, it's not fair. Let's work on changing the system. Go!

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3.I wish I had told the admissions committee when I was applying to college that I was proud of being a graduate of my high school, despite its average academic record.

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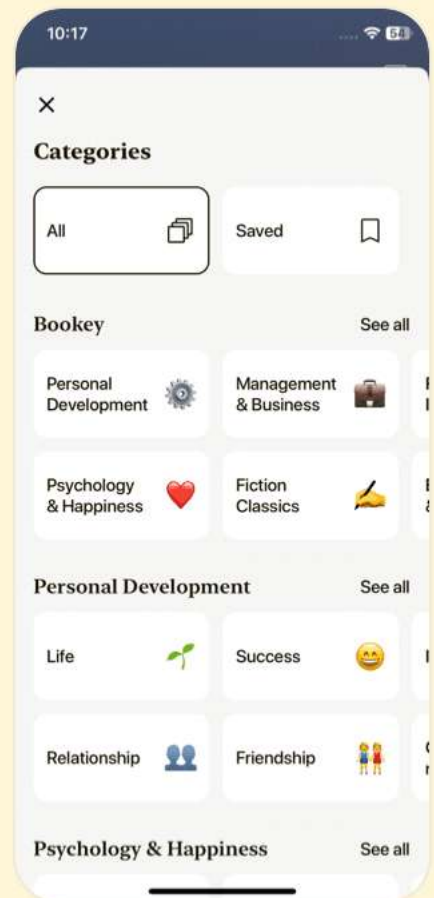
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Chapter 22 | Quotes From Pages 389-391

1. Gap years are nonschool years between high school and university. Popular in Europe and increasingly popular in the United States, they allow students to work, travel, or volunteer before the commitment of college.
2. But I advised students to be honest about their intended majors, even if undecided, since betting on 'which majors we might need' could be a losing bet.
3. I never understood why a student would apply to all eight Ivies, considering the schools are so different from one another. It seemed suspiciously elitist to me.

Chapter 23 | Quotes From Pages 394-396

1. I spent the night before I was dropped off at college in the bathroom of a Holiday Inn. It was the day Princess Diana had died. My parents were glued to the television. My sister was glued to her comic books. And I was glued to the bathroom floor. I was incredibly nervous. But the second I



climbed the stairs to my dorm room and was greeted by smiley roommates who offered to carry in my mini fridge, I knew I'd be okay.

2. My husband missed only one class during his four years at Dartmouth (to attend his grandmother's funeral). By his math, each class cost approximately three hundred dollars. As a student on financial aid, he wasn't going to squander that investment. He went to classes hungover, sick, and half asleep. But he always got his bum in a seat.

3. Interestingly, in my entire career, I was invited to only one college graduation party. But I received plenty of invites to high school seniors' senior plays before they were admitted.

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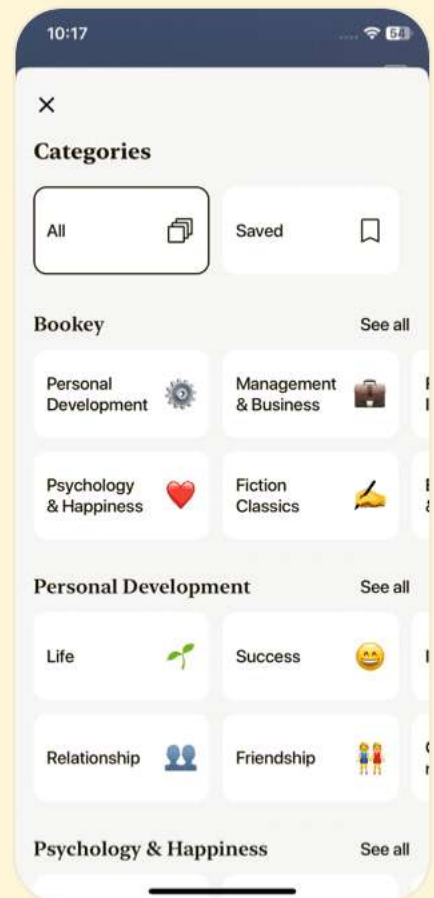
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Chapter 1 | First Steps| Q&A

1.Question

What are the top three tips for high school freshmen to prepare for college?

Answer:1. Take ‘challenging, yet appropriate’

classes: Engage in courses that are suitable for your skill level, ensuring a strong transcript. 2.

Familiarize yourself with the counseling office:

Utilize the resources available to understand curriculum tracks and college requirements. 3.

Develop writing skills: Improve your writing through various formats, as strong writing abilities will aid in crafting college applications.

2.Question

Why is it important for students to have discussions about college early on?

Answer:Early discussions about college can help students

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understand its significance, opportunities, and the variety of educational paths available. It prepares them to make informed decisions and explore their interests before the pressure mounts in junior and senior years.

3.Question

How can parents approach the topic of college without causing anxiety in their children?

Answer:Parents should initiate informal conversations about college, integrating it into everyday scenarios rather than presenting it as a stress-inducing topic. Engage in discussions that promote curiosity and exploration of academic interests rather than solely focusing on admissions.

4.Question

What misconception do many parents have about preparing their children for college?

Answer:Many parents mistakenly focus too early on college admissions requirements, worrying about résumés and achievements instead of encouraging their children to enjoy high school, cultivate interests, and learn for the sake of

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personal growth.

5.Question

What should students prioritize during their high school years instead of obsessing over college?

Answer: Students should focus on exploring their interests, trying new activities, and developing foundational skills.

Engaging in high school life will prepare them more effectively for college than solely grand ambitions for elite institutions.

6.Question

What was the significant lesson related to college admissions drawn from the experiences of the students in the presentation?

Answer: The path to college is unique for every student, and interest in college will develop over time. It's important for students to find their own motivations and to appreciate the high school experience itself rather than fixate solely on the future.

Chapter 2 | Creating the Right College List| Q&A

1.Question

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What is the first step in creating a college list according to the author?

Answer: Get excited about more than one school. It's important to have multiple schools on your list that you genuinely like, rather than fixating solely on one 'dream' school.

2.Question

Why is it important to consider a range of selectivity when applying to colleges?

Answer: Having a mix of schools with varying admission competitiveness increases the chances of acceptance and allows for choices that fit your aspirations and qualifications better.

3.Question

What role do finances play in the college selection process?

Answer: Students and their families should have open conversations about college affordability and ensure that all schools on the list are personally affordable without

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accumulating large amounts of debt.

4.Question

What should students remember about 'safety schools'?

Answer:Students should apply to colleges they want to attend, not just safety schools. The term 'safety school' suggests a lack of enthusiasm; any college on your list should be a place you would be happy to attend.

5.Question

How did Marco feel about his college choice, and what does this suggest about his selection process?

Answer:Marco seemed indifferent about attending State Y, viewing it as a second choice after being denied from more prestigious schools. This suggests he may have not kept an open mind during his selection process or based his choices too heavily on peer influence.

6.Question

What advice does the author give for students who are uncertain about their college choices?

Answer:Students should keep an open mind about various schools, do thorough research, take time to explore options

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that excite them, and focus on how well those schools align with their personal interests and goals.

7.Question

How does the author view the relationship between college rankings and personal opportunity?

Answer:The author believes that personal opportunity and college rankings do not always align; what matters more is the fit and individual experiences at a school rather than its prestige.

8.Question

What is the emotional takeaway the author wants readers to have about their college journey?

Answer:The author hopes students will feel excited about their future opportunities and take the time to thoughtfully consider their college choices, embracing the potential for each college to transform their lives.

Chapter 3 | The Campus Visit| Q&A

1.Question

What should prospective students do to maximize their college visit experience?

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Answer: Prospective students should take initiative by wandering off the beaten path during their campus visits. This includes eating in the dining hall to observe campus energy, attending meetings with faculty or student club advisors to gain insights into their interests, roaming the hallways of academic departments to assess resources and environment, and paying attention to student center announcements to understand what matters to the student body.

2.Question

Why is it important for students to research colleges beyond the marketing materials?

Answer: Colleges often present their best image through marketing materials, but firsthand experiences during a visit—such as engaging with current students, exploring academic departments, or observing campus life—offer deeper insights into what a college community is truly like.

3.Question

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How can students demonstrate their authentic interest in a college during the application process?

Answer: Students can demonstrate their interest by sharing specific experiences in their application essays, like mentioning a conversation with a faculty member, an observation from a campus visit, or unique insights they gained from eating in the dining hall or attending a campus event that resonated with their academic or personal interests.

4.Question

What role does 'demonstrated interest' play in college admissions?

Answer: Demonstrated interest is significant in college admissions, as it indicates how seriously a candidate is considering a school. Actions like visiting, pre-registering for tours, or reaching out to admissions offices reflect a level of commitment that colleges may value when evaluating applications.

5.Question

Why might some students feel intimidated during college admissions visits, and how can they overcome this?

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Answer:Some students may feel intimidated by the formality or perceived exclusivity of college admissions visits, but they can overcome this by remembering that they have the power of choice in the application process. Approaching visits with curiosity, asking questions, and engaging with current students and faculty demystifies the experience and enhances their understanding of the school.

6.Question

What advantages did the author find in eating at the dining hall during visits?

Answer:Eating at the dining hall allows prospective students to witness campus energy, observe social dynamics among students, and overhear authentic conversations, providing insight into the student culture that can't be captured through official tours.

7.Question

How can students personalize their college applications based on campus visits?

Answer:Students can personalize their applications by

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incorporating specific insights gained during their visits, like mentioning unique facilities they've seen, conversations they've had, or specific programs that resonate with their goals, thereby creating a more compelling narrative about why they are drawn to that particular school.

8.Question

What does the author suggest students do if they are unable to visit campuses?

Answer:If students cannot physically visit campuses, they should engage in extensive online research, such as virtual tours, attending online admissions events, reading campus newspapers, and reaching out to departments or student organizations to gather as much information as possible about the college.

9.Question

In what ways can prospective students become 'campus investigators'?

Answer:Prospective students can become 'campus investigators' by proactively exploring campus beyond the

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official tours—asking questions of current students and faculty, seeking out and engaging with various student organizations and academic departments, and investigating physical spaces that interest them.

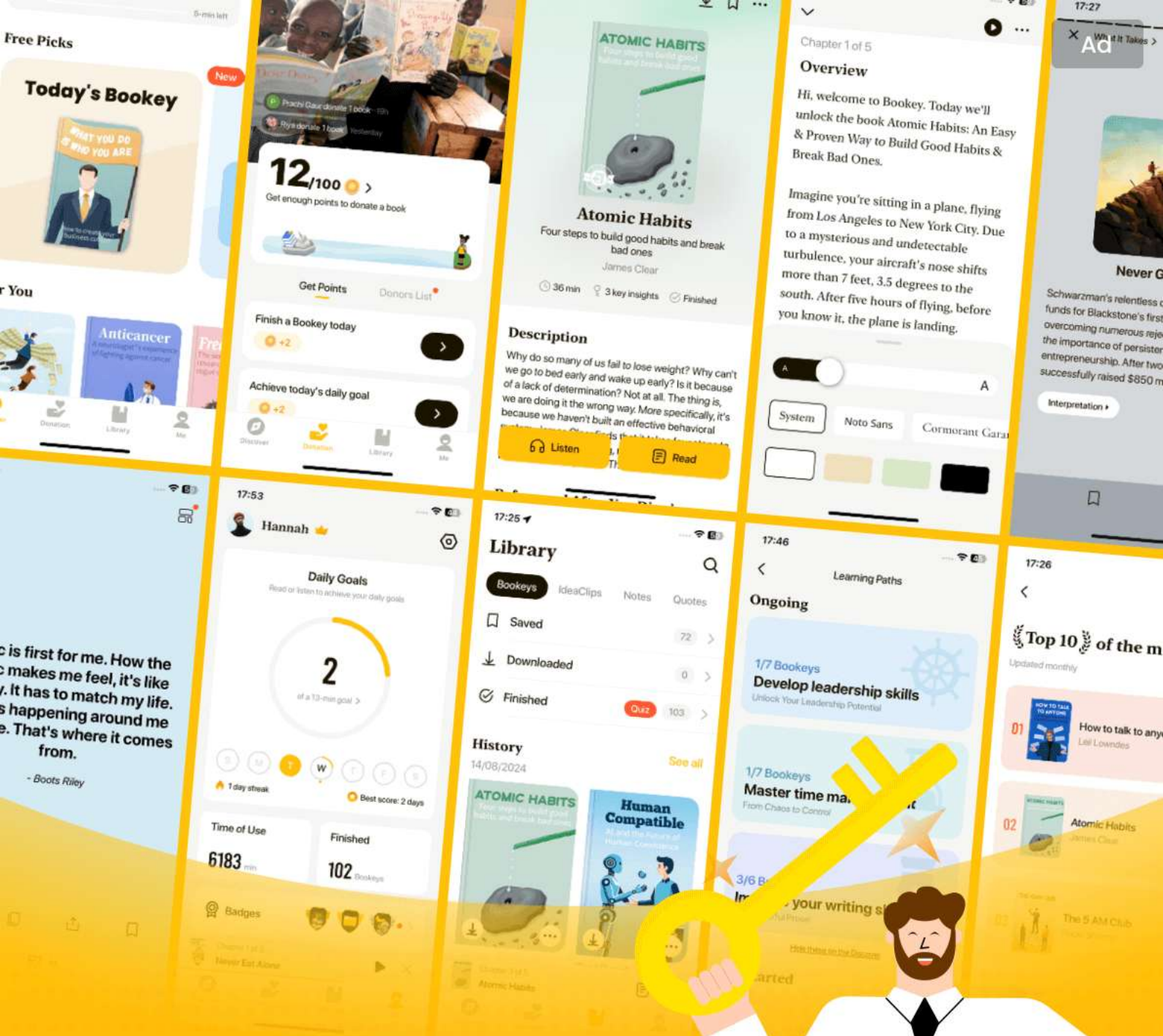
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Chapter 4 | Coming to a High School Near You| Q&A

1.Question

What qualities make a prospective student stand out to an admissions officer?

Answer:The most impressive students lead with their person, not just their accolades. They ask questions that go beyond typical inquiries, often seeking ungoogleable answers. They act as ambassadors for their schools by clearly articulating their school's unique strengths, and they celebrate their peers rather than compete against them.

2.Question

How can students effectively engage with their regional admissions officer?

Answer:Students should reach out to their regional admissions officer by introducing themselves, sharing unique aspects of their school, community, or personal experiences, and make clear their interest in the college. A follow-up email summarizing their conversation can enhance their

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visibility.

3.Question

Why is Layla considered the most memorable student among all the thousands met by the author?

Answer:Layla's curiosity set her apart; she asked thoughtful, unexpected questions that showed depth. Her kindness and eagerness to engage, as well as her strong interest in learning about both the college and her community, left a lasting impression on the author, even if she never applied.

4.Question

What does the author believe should change regarding admissions recruitment practices?

Answer:The author advocates for a shift in recruitment practices towards more inclusive and equitable approaches, suggesting that colleges stop focusing on elite high schools and instead engage more with schools that serve diverse populations, thereby ensuring that they truly support a wider range of students.

5.Question

What lesson does the author convey about perception in

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the admissions process?

Answer: The author emphasizes that admissions officers are human and become weary of perfection. They find genuine curiosity, kindness, and authenticity more impressive than just a strong resume, indicating that character matters significantly in the admissions process.

6.Question

How can a student effectively follow up after meeting an admissions officer?

Answer: A student could write a personalized email referencing specific details from their conversation, highlighting their continued interest in the college, and mentioning what they appreciate about the school. This keeps the connection alive and strengthens their candidacy.

7.Question

What role does personal interaction play in the admissions process according to the author?

Answer: Personal interactions are crucial as they allow students to showcase their true personalities, curiosity, and

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kindness, attributes that numbers and grades cannot convey. These interactions can influence an admissions officer's impression and help a student stand out among a pool of applicants.

8.Question

What advice does the author give about the misconceptions students might have regarding college admissions?

Answer:Students may believe that a straightforward list of achievements is enough to impress admissions officers, but the author suggests that personal connection, unique questions, and authenticity are what truly resonate. They should not solely rely on their accomplishments.

9.Question

What is the significance of having a diverse student exposé during the recruitment process?

Answer:A diverse student exposé helps admissions officers understand the varied backgrounds and contexts of applicants, which is essential for creating a well-rounded and inclusive community in colleges.

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Chapter 5 | The School Report| Q&A

1.Question

What should students prioritize when considering their high school choices and academic paths?

Answer:Students should prioritize what will best educate, enlighten, and inspire them, rather than solely focusing on what looks good to admissions committees. Taking classes that challenge their interests and help them grow should be the focus.

2.Question

How should students handle concerns about their grades in challenging courses?

Answer:Students should articulate their experiences in challenging courses and, if necessary, provide context to admissions committees about their academic choices, emphasizing personal growth over just the grade achieved.

3.Question

Why is understanding the high school profile important for students?

Answer:Understanding the high school profile is important

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as it helps students see how their school's offerings, grading systems, and policies affect their transcript and overall application. It provides a framework that can influence how their performance is interpreted by admissions officers.

4.Question

What personal experiences should students convey in their applications?

Answer:Students should convey personal experiences that show how they've faced challenges, pursued interests, or made significant academic decisions. They should share stories that demonstrate growth, resilience, and personal ambition, such as overcoming a fear through performance or pursuing a subject with passion.

5.Question

What should students do if their school's academic options are limited?

Answer:Students should be proactive in contextualizing their academic experiences, taking the initiative to inform admissions committees of relevant factors that might affect

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their academic performance, such as limited course availability or counseling support. They can use the 'Additional Information' section on applications to clarify their situations.

6.Question

How should students choose between different courses or electives?

Answer:Students should choose courses based on their personal interests and career goals rather than merely what will enhance their GPA or class ranking. They should consider how each course will contribute to their overall education and personal development.

7.Question

How can students effectively advocate for themselves in the application process?

Answer:Students can effectively advocate for themselves by communicating openly with counselors about their academic histories, proactively requesting letters of recommendation, and writing supplementary materials that explain their unique

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situations, challenges, and motivations.

8.Question

What is a common misconception students have about how admissions committees view their applications?

Answer:A common misconception is that admissions committees prioritize grades and ranks above all else. In reality, they value students' efforts, challenges overcome, and the context of their educational experiences just as much as numerical metrics.

9.Question

Why is it essential for students to reflect on their high school experiences?

Answer:Reflecting on their high school experiences allows students to understand their unique academic and personal journeys, helping them articulate their individuality in applications. This reflection fosters self-awareness and enhances their ability to convey their stories to admissions committees.

Chapter 6 | Recommendations| Q&A

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1.Question

Why are letters of recommendation important in college admissions?

Answer:Letters of recommendation confirm attributes that transcripts may not capture, such as a student's character, kindness, and intellectual curiosity. They provide a holistic view of the candidate, showing how they interact with others, their willingness to help, and their creativity, thus influencing their chances of admission.

2.Question

What is a memorable example of a letter of recommendation from the chapter?

Answer:A remarkable letter came from a custodian who praised a student for being the only one to learn his name and for picking up trash in the hallways. This letter highlighted the student's kindness and character, offering a unique perspective that academic scores alone could not convey.

3.Question

How can a student select the right recommender?

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Answer: Students should choose recommenders who can speak to both their academic and personal qualities. It is crucial to pick teachers who have had a significant impact on their intellectual growth, rather than the ones who simply gave the highest grades.

4.Question

What qualities make a recommendation letter effective?

Answer: Effective letters are specific, use descriptive adjectives, reframe superlatives, and present new insights about the student. They should tell a compelling story that highlights both academic abilities and personal traits.

5.Question

Why is the narrative aspect of recommendations crucial?

Answer: Narratives reveal the student's humanity—how they use their skills and knowledge in real-life situations, which resonates more deeply with admissions committees than mere grades. A student's unique stories can set them apart from other qualified applicants.

6.Question

How can students strengthen their relationship with

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teachers for better recommendations?

Answer: Students should build authentic relationships with their teachers by engaging in learning, participating actively in class, and expressing gratitude. Open communication about their academic interests and future goals can help teachers write more impactful recommendations.

7.Question

What should a student do if they want to submit an additional recommendation?

Answer: Students should consider submitting an additional recommendation from someone who can provide a fresh perspective on their candidacy, such as a mentor or employer, but avoid adding letters from individuals who do not have specific, meaningful insights.

8.Question

How can students help their recommenders?

Answer: Students can assist their recommenders by asking for recommendations early, providing updates on their accomplishments, and sharing their college application

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journey with them. This allows recommenders to personalize their letters more effectively.

9.Question

What common mistake do recommenders make when writing letters?

Answer:A common mistake is writing vague letters that do not distinguish the student from others. This often happens due to rushed writing or a lack of specific interaction with the student.

10.Question

What ultimately matters in a recommendation letter, according to the chapter's insights?

Answer:The most important factor in a recommendation letter is how well the recommender knows the applicant and their specific contributions, rather than the status of the recommender. Personal anecdotes and detailed observations carry more weight than generic praise.

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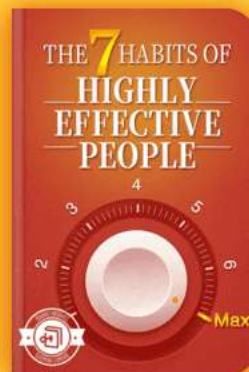
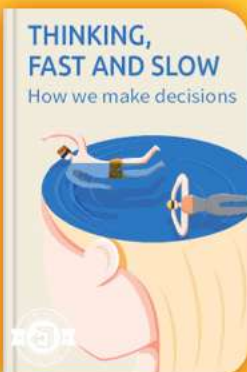


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Chapter 7 | Extracurriculars| Q&A

1.Question

What is the primary message about extracurricular activities according to the author?

Answer:The author emphasizes that students should engage in extracurricular activities out of genuine interest and passion, not just to build a résumé for college admissions. The focus should be on enjoying the experience and discovering true passions rather than checking boxes for elite status.

2.Question

How should students approach the college admissions process according to the author?

Answer:Students should prioritize depth over breadth in their extracurricular activities, engage authentically in what they love, and not succumb to the pressure of doing everything or appearing 'perfect' on paper.

3.Question

What does the author mean by 'taking time to teenage'?

Answer:'Taking time to teenage' refers to the importance of

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engaging in typical teenage experiences—like socializing, discovering oneself, and experimenting with different interests—rather than becoming overly focused on achievements that may look good for college applications.

4.Question

What are some nontraditional activities that the author believes should be valued?

Answer:Activities such as caring for younger siblings, engaging in neighborhood projects, or personal hobbies (like cooking or crafting) are as significant as traditional extracurriculars because they shape who a person is and demonstrate responsibility and passion.

5.Question

Why does the author criticize students who are overly fixated on achievements like awards and titles?

Answer:The author critiques this approach because it often leads to a shallow engagement with activities, where the focus is solely on accolades rather than the joy and learning that can come from involvement. This can result in students

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missing out on meaningful experiences.

6.Question

How can students strengthen their applications in regard to extracurriculars?

Answer:Students should list their activities in order of significance, provide detailed descriptions of their roles and achievements, and focus on a few meaningful commitments rather than trying to list every minor involvement or award.

7.Question

What is the significance of the anecdote about Lily?

Answer:Lily's story illustrates the dangers of losing oneself in the pursuit of academic perfection and acceptance by colleges. Despite her achievements, the author questions whether she might miss out on the joys of life and personal fulfillment, emphasizing the importance of balance.

8.Question

What does the author suggest is a more meaningful path for students?

Answer:The author suggests that students should engage in their interests and activities with curiosity and enthusiasm,

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allowing themselves the freedom to explore who they are, which may lead to becoming not only better college applicants but more well-rounded and fulfilled individuals.

9.Question

How does the author propose to address the pressures of college admissions?

Answer:The author advocates for a shift in perspective where colleges value authenticity and personal interests over a checklist of accomplishments, encouraging students to embrace their individuality and enjoy their high school experience.

10.Question

What message does the author want to convey to parents regarding their children's extracurricular involvement?

Answer:The author urges parents to support their children in finding and pursuing their genuine interests rather than pushing them into activities for the sake of college admissions competitiveness.

Chapter 8 | Testing| Q&A

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1.Question

How should students view their standardized test scores in relation to their overall potential?

Answer:Students should view standardized test scores as just one aspect of their application, not a definitive measure of their intellectual potential.

They should remember that a score doesn't encompass their entire academic journey or capabilities.

2.Question

In what ways can socioeconomic status affect standardized test scores?

Answer:Research indicates that students from wealthier backgrounds tend to score higher on standardized tests due to better access to resources, tutoring, and educational support, highlighting systemic inequalities in education.

3.Question

What does the author believe about the predictiveness of standardized test scores?

Answer:The author believes that standardized test scores are

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not entirely predictive of a student's success in college, as many variables—including background and personal circumstances—play a crucial role.

4.Question

What is the significance of the holistic approach in college admissions?

Answer:The holistic approach in college admissions considers a student's entire application, including personal statements and extracurricular activities, rather than focusing solely on test scores. This helps ensure a more equitable evaluation of candidates.

5.Question

What advice does the author give to students regarding standardized tests?

Answer:The author advises students to prepare early, utilize resources available for test preparation, not to obsess over scores from multiple tests, and to remember that scores should be viewed contextually within their overall application.

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6.Question

Why does the author focus on the stories and contexts of students rather than just their test scores?

Answer:The author emphasizes considering students' individual stories, backgrounds, and experiences because these factors provide a deeper understanding of their potential and challenges, which test scores alone cannot reflect.

7.Question

What impact can test-optional policies have on college admissions?

Answer:Test-optional policies can encourage a more diverse applicant pool by allowing students who may not perform well on tests to apply without the pressure of standardized scores affecting their chances.

8.Question

How should students communicate about lower test scores in their applications?

Answer:Students can use the 'Additional Information' section of their applications to provide context around lower test

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scores without making excuses, emphasizing their unique circumstances and strengths.

9.Question

What does the author suggest is one reason students might underestimate their potential?

Answer:Students may underestimate their potential due to perceived disparities in their test scores compared to other applicants, leading them to think they do not belong in competitive applicant pools.

10.Question

What is the takeaway regarding the relationship between test scores and a student's identity?

Answer:The takeaway is that a student's identity and value should not be defined by their test scores; they represent only a fraction of who they are and what they can achieve academically and personally.

Chapter 9 | The Personal Statement| Q&A

1.Question

What is the overall purpose of a personal statement in college applications?

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Answer: The purpose of a personal statement is to share a personal story, vision, or thought about oneself that provides context to the application. It should be a human narrative that reflects the applicant's unique experiences and insights rather than aiming to create a 'Great American College Essay'.

2.Question

What are some key tips for writing an effective personal statement?

Answer: 1. Be specific: Focus on particular moments rather than general summaries.

2. Write about yourself, not others: The essay should center on your experiences and insights.

3. Choose a topic only you can write about: It should be personal and unique to your experiences.

4. Ensure your main takeaway is clear: Admissions officers should easily summarize the main point of your essay.

3.Question

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Why should students avoid writing about common topics like grandparents or heroes?

Answer: Common topics may result in essays that lack originality. These topics are too familiar and many students might write similar essays, making them less memorable to admissions officers.

4.Question

What kind of essay topics are likely to make an applicant stand out?

Answer: Essays that discuss unique, personal experiences or moments that reveal personality tend to be more impactful. For example, an essay about 'The Art of Refereeing Toddler Soccer' would be more unique and engaging than a typical 'My Grandmother Is My Hero' essay.

5.Question

How should students approach the essay-writing process according to the author?

Answer: Students should view the essay as an opportunity to share something personal that is meaningful to them. It's

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important to relax, write honestly, and not aim for an award-winning essay. The focus should be on genuine self-reflection and individual storytelling.

6.Question

What example does the author give of an effective personal statement?

Answer:The author shares the story of a young woman named Laurie who discussed her internship at a zoo where, instead of working directly with animals, she was tasked with being a park greeter. This essay was effective because it highlighted Laurie's passion for zoology, her willingness to take on an unglamorous task, her sense of humor, and her commitment.

7.Question

What does the author mean when they say "the admissions process isn't meant to be an essay contest"?

Answer:This means that the selection process is not solely based on the quality of the essay. While personal statements add character to an applicant's profile, admissions decisions

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consider various aspects of the application, not just the essays.

8.Question

How can students ensure their essay aligns with what admissions officers are looking for?

Answer:Students should aim for clarity and specificity in their essays. They can practice summarizing their main point in a single sentence to assess whether it conveys what they want the admissions officer to take away from their writing.

9.Question

What key emotion should personal statements evoke according to the author?

Answer:Personal statements should evoke authenticity and heartfulness, providing a genuine glimpse into the applicant's life, experiences, and personal growth.

10.Question

Why is it suggested that students not overthink their essay topics?

Answer:Overthinking can lead to topic paralysis and the fear of choosing an 'insignificant' topic. Students should

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recognize that heartfelt stories, even if simple or mundane,
can be the most impactful.

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Chapter 10 | Supplemental Essays| Q&A

1.Question

Why are supplemental essays important in college applications?

Answer:Supplemental essays give applicants the chance to share more personal details about themselves beyond grades and scores. They can reveal their personality, interests, and thought processes, allowing admissions officers to see applicants as more than just numbers. A strong supplemental essay can enhance an application significantly, emphasizing the applicant's seriousness and unique qualities.

2.Question

What is a common mistake students make when writing supplemental essays?

Answer:Many students tend to write vague or generic responses that do not truly reflect their experiences or perspectives. For example, stating 'soccer teaches me

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teamwork' lacks depth and specificity, failing to provide insight into the applicant's character or contributions.

3.Question

How can students make their supplemental essays stand out?

Answer:Students can make their essays stand out by providing specific examples that highlight their unique experiences and insights. Instead of giving generic answers, they should focus on unique anecdotes or specific details that showcase their personality and reflection, like using a specific art project to illustrate personal growth.

4.Question

What is the role of specificity in answering supplemental questions?

Answer:Specificity in supplemental questions helps applicants create a clearer picture of themselves for the admissions officers. By outlining distinct thoughts, experiences, or choices, applicants can make a stronger case for why they would be a good fit for the college, showing

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that they have thought carefully about the questions.

5.Question

Why do colleges ask unique questions in supplemental essays?

Answer:Colleges ask unique questions to engage applicants in a more personal and meaningful way, allowing them to stand out as individuals. This helps colleges assess fit and interest in their specific institution, as they gather insights that go beyond traditional metrics.

6.Question

What can students do if they find supplemental essays overwhelming?

Answer:Students can break down the supplemental essay requirements into smaller, manageable tasks, focusing on one question at a time. They could also seek inspiration from experiences in their lives or from friends who have gone through the process. Engaging with a teacher or mentor for feedback can also help alleviate the pressure.

7.Question

In what ways do supplemental essays serve as marketing

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tools for colleges?

Answer: Supplemental essays can highlight specific strengths or attributes of a college, encouraging applicants to consider how those align with their interests. By asking targeted questions, colleges can market their unique aspects, such as departments or values, while also enticing students to demonstrate their knowledge and appreciation of those elements.

8.Question

What does it mean when the author states that the essay is the heart and the supplement is the soul of the application?

Answer: This metaphor emphasizes that while the personal statement (the heart) provides the main thrust of a candidate's application by showcasing their primary narratives, supplemental essays (the soul) add depth, personality, and individual flair, making the application more holistic and engaging.

Chapter 11 | Submitting the Application| Q&A

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1.Question

What is the key to a successful college application according to Chapter 11?

Answer:The key to a successful college application is to care about the application just as much as one cares about the college itself. This means paying attention to both the small details and the larger aspects of the application.

2.Question

How many applications does an admissions director read on average, and what does this signify about the application review process?

Answer:An admissions director reads approximately 130 applications per week, which highlights the volume of applications and the need for applicants to make their submissions stand out.

3.Question

What advice is given for filling out the college application?

Answer:The advice given includes strategically considering

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the holistic view of the application, focusing on how to present strengths in different sections, and being as descriptive as possible.

4.Question

Why is the 'Additional Information' section important in a college application?

Answer:The 'Additional Information' section is important because it allows applicants to share details about their experiences, background, and personal stories that may not be reflected elsewhere in the application.

5.Question

What can be the impact of seemingly trivial details in an application process?

Answer:Seemingly trivial details, such as an email address or the way information is presented in the application, can significantly impact an admissions decision by revealing aspects of a student's character and attention to detail.

6.Question

What were some specific examples of applicants' details that made an impression in the admissions process?

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Answer: An example includes an applicant whose email address was a playful reference which raised questions about maturity, or a student's family information that provided insights into their character and values.

7.Question

What should students avoid in their applications regarding effort and care?

Answer: Students should avoid being lazy or careless in their applications. Failing to fill out every section thoroughly, including optional materials, could lead to a weaker application compared to others who capitalize on all opportunities.

8.Question

How does the chapter describe the relationship between the detail of an application and the chances of admission?

Answer: The chapter suggests that more detailed applications with rich information allow admissions officers to better assess candidates, ultimately improving their chances of admission as opposed to standard or flat applications.

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9.Question

In what ways does this chapter suggest that the college application process is similar to self-marketing?

Answer:The college application process is likened to self-marketing as it requires applicants to present their best selves, reflect on their experiences, and strategically highlight their qualifications in order to make a compelling case for admission.

10.Question

What is the ultimate takeaway from the chapter regarding college applications?

Answer:The ultimate takeaway is that while there is no guaranteed formula for a successful application, applicants should seek to fully engage in the process and avoid regrets by being thorough and attentive to even the smallest details.

Chapter 12 | Alumni Interviews| Q&A

1.Question

What should a prospective student focus on during an alumni interview?

Answer:A prospective student should focus on

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showing their personality, discussing their unique experiences, and conveying their passion. They should use the interview to confirm information on their application, expand on details, and demonstrate their humanity through relatable stories or insights that might not have made it onto their application.

2.Question

Why is it important for alumni interviews to take place in public settings?

Answer:Alumni interviews are conducted in public settings primarily for safety reasons, ensuring both the student and the interviewer feel secure. Public venues minimize risks associated with private meetings, and they also help maintain a professional atmosphere.

3.Question

How can students make the most of their alumni interview?

Answer:Students can make the most of their alumni

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interview by bringing a résumé to remind interviewers of their accomplishments, sharing unique personal experiences that aren't listed in their applications, asking insightful questions about the alumni's experiences, and expressing gratitude for the interviewer's time.

4.Question

What are some potential challenges of the alumni interview process for applicants?

Answer:Challenges for applicants may include not being offered an interview due to availability, the pressure to perform well and stand out among strong candidates, and the possibility that a negative impression in an interview could overshadow their written application.

5.Question

How does the alumni interview contribute to the college admissions process?

Answer:The alumni interview adds a personal touch to the admissions process, allowing admissions committees to assess a candidate's personality, motivations, and

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engagement in a way that can't be captured on paper. It also helps keep alumni connected to the institution.

6.Question

What role does positivity play in the interview experience?

Answer:Positivity is crucial because it enhances the interaction; when students express enjoyment and appreciation during the interview, it boosts the overall atmosphere for both parties. This positivity creates a more memorable and impactful experience, which can influence the interviewer's perception of the candidate.

7.Question

Can strong alumni interviews change an applicant's fate in the admissions process?

Answer:Yes, strong alumni interviews can lead to a reevaluation of an applicant by the admissions committee. If an interview stands out positively, especially after an initial rejection, it might prompt the committee to take a second look at the application.

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8.Question

What are the three main aspects that alumni interviews confirm about applicants?

Answer: The three main aspects alumni interviews confirm are the authenticity of the application (confirmation of claims made), the expansion of narrative about the applicant's interests and experiences, and the demonstration of their human side through personal stories and interactions.

9.Question

Why did the author find the alumni interview process both charitable and relevant?

Answer: The author found the alumni interview process charitable because it fosters connections between prospective students and alumni who genuinely want to help. It is relevant as it adds a necessary human element to the admissions process, helping colleges assess applicants beyond their written applications.

10.Question

How might negative interviews impact the admissions decision compared to positive ones?

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Answer:Negative interviews tend to have a more significant impact on admissions decisions because they are rare and memorable, leading committees to scrutinize any unfavorable feedback. Positive interviews, while pleasant, often do not tip the scales as decisively as a negative experience might affect a candidate's chances.

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Chapter 13 | A Word on Early| Q&A

1.Question

What are the advantages of applying early to colleges like Dartmouth?

Answer:Applying early can statistically improve one's chances of admission, especially for non-athlete applicants. Many colleges, including Dartmouth, may offer a higher acceptance rate for early applicants. Early decision applications provide students the relief of admissions notifications much earlier than regular applications, often by mid-December.

2.Question

What is the difference between early decision and early action?

Answer:Early decision is a binding agreement, meaning that if a student is accepted, they must attend that college.

Conversely, early action is non-binding, allowing students to receive their decision early without the obligation to enroll.

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3.Question

What financial implications should students consider when applying early?

Answer:Students applying early decision may miss out on comparing financial aid packages from different schools, as they can only consider the aid from the school they are applying early to. This could potentially lead to financial challenges if the aid offered doesn't meet their needs.

4.Question

What are some challenges that students might face when applying early?

Answer:Students might struggle if they haven't yet identified their top choice college, submit incomplete applications, or if their grades are not strong due to 'senioritis'. Additionally, the competitive early pool can be a hurdle requiring serious consideration.

5.Question

How can deferred students improve their chances of admission later?

Answer:Deferred students should submit their midyear

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transcripts and an update email including any new achievements or continued interest in the college, emphasizing that it remains their first choice.

6.Question

How should students approach the decision to apply early?

Answer:Students should carefully weigh the pros and cons, consider their personal circumstances, be realistic about their chances, and ensure they are well-prepared to submit strong applications.

7.Question

What advice is given to students about securing recommendations for early applications?

Answer:Students should ask their teachers for recommendations well in advance, ideally more than a week prior to the deadline, to ensure teachers have enough time to write thoughtful and comprehensive letters.

8.Question

What overarching theme emerges about the pressures of early college applications?

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Answer: The theme emphasizes balancing the advantages of applying early with the potential pressures and risks involved, highlighting the need for informed decision-making and preparation.

9.Question

What is the recommendation for students considering early programs in the admissions process?

Answer: Students are encouraged to research early program policies thoroughly and to consider their financial aid options, competitiveness, and their own readiness before deciding to apply early.

Chapter 14 | International Applicants| Q&A

1.Question

What are the main challenges faced by international applicants when applying to U.S. colleges?

Answer: International applicants face several challenges, including difficulty navigating testing locations, understanding financial aid paperwork specific to their citizenship status, and the

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competitive nature of admissions processes which consider their ability to pay tuition.

2.Question

How does Dartmouth define an international applicant?

Answer:At Dartmouth, an international applicant is defined as a student who does not hold a U.S. passport. Permanent residents, eligible noncitizens, and undocumented students are exceptions and reviewed similarly to American citizens.

3.Question

What does 'need-aware' mean in the context of college admissions for international students?

Answer:'Need-aware' means that colleges consider a student's financial need when making admissions decisions. For international applicants, colleges like Dartmouth assess the student's ability to pay tuition, which influences their chances of being admitted.

4.Question

What steps can international students take to enhance their application?

Answer:International students should provide context about

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their schooling, utilize diverse recommendations beyond traditional counselors, and take testing requirements seriously, ensuring they prepare adequately for standardized tests that can validate their academic readiness.

5.Question

What is the significance of diversity in the international student body at colleges like Dartmouth?

Answer:Diversity among international students enriches the campus community by elevating academic discussions and broadening cultural, linguistic, and religious perspectives, enhancing the overall educational experience for all students.

6.Question

How can international applicants best approach financial aid in their college applications?

Answer:International applicants should realistically assess their ability to pay tuition and indicate their financial aid status clearly on their applications, as this will affect their eligibility for aid if admitted.

7.Question

What common sentiments do international students

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express regarding their identity at college?

Answer:International students often express a desire to be seen as individuals beyond their nationality, wanting recognition for their unique experiences and perspectives rather than being categorized solely by their citizenship.

8.Question

What strategies do colleges employ to recruit international students?

Answer:Colleges use various strategies for international recruitment, including traveling abroad to visit schools, meeting with local organizations, and participating in fairs to connect with potential applicants while highlighting their school's attributes and advantages.

Chapter 15 | Recruited Athletes| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of the Academic Index in evaluating athletic recruits?

Answer:The Academic Index (AI) serves as a standardized measure to evaluate whether athletic

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recruits meet the academic standards required by the Ivy League. While it factors in GPA and test scores, it has limitations as it does not account for the strength of course curriculum. Therefore, while a strong AI can signal academic capability, it may not fully capture a student's readiness or potential to thrive at the college level.

2.Question

How should athletes approach their college applications according to the admissions office's perspective?

Answer: Athletes should view themselves as students first when approaching their college applications. This involves starting the process early, communicating directly with coaches about their recruitment status, actively listening to feedback, and writing compelling essays that reflect their personal growth outside of athletics.

3.Question

Why is it important for student-athletes to balance athletics and academics?

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Answer:Balancing athletics and academics is crucial for student-athletes to ensure they are prepared for the rigors of college. Success in college requires strong academic skills and time management, which can prevent the athlete's academic performance from hindering their athletic opportunities.

4.Question

What red flags do admissions officers look for in athlete applications?

Answer:Admissions officers are concerned about discrepancies like low grades in core subjects, lack of effort shown in transcripts, and poorly written essays. They are keen to reject candidates who display signs of laziness or entitlement, as these traits can indicate future difficulties in a rigorous academic environment.

5.Question

What does the narrative suggest about the relationship between athletics and admissions decisions?

Answer:The narrative illustrates a complex relationship

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where athletic talent can afford recruits preferential treatment within the admissions process, but there is a strong emphasis on academic excellence and personal responsibility.

Admissions decisions are ultimately made with the understanding that both academic and athletic capabilities must be present for a student-athlete to succeed.

6.Question

What life lessons can be derived from the admissions process described in the chapter?

Answer:Key lessons from the admissions process include the importance of diligence, integrity, and holistic development—both academically and athletically. Students are advised to treat every aspect of their application with seriousness and to recognize that true respect is garnered not only through athletic ability but through academic dedication and personal growth.

7.Question

How can a poorly completed application affect an athletic recruit's chances?

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Answer: A poorly completed application can severely diminish an athletic recruit's chances of admission, regardless of their sports talent. It reflects a lack of effort and can raise concerns about the student's preparedness for the academic challenges of college life.

8.Question

What advice is given for writing the college application essay?

Answer: Students are advised not to focus their essays solely on sports achievements. Instead, they should illustrate other dimensions of their character and experiences, such as unique interests, community work, or personal challenges that demonstrate growth.

9.Question

What role do coaches play in the athletic recruit admissions process?

Answer: Coaches serve as the primary contact between recruits and the admissions office, guiding athletes through the admissions process and relaying information about

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academic readiness and application status. Their involvement is crucial in advocating for their recruits while ensuring that admissions policies are upheld.

10.Question

How does an athlete's academic performance influence their recruitment, as suggested in the narrative?

Answer:An athlete's academic performance is pivotal in their recruitment. Even talented athletes must demonstrate readiness through their academic record, as admissions officers will reject candidates who do not meet academic standards or show a commitment to their studies.

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Chapter 16 | Decision Day| Q&A

1.Question

What are the emotional aspects students deal with on decision day?

Answer:Students experience a range of emotions on decision day—joy from acceptances, frustration or heartbreak from rejections, and lingering hope from being waitlisted. The uncertainty and pressure can amplify these feelings, often leading to an emotional roller coaster.

2.Question

How should students handle rejection from a college they desired?

Answer:Students should recognize that rejection is a common experience and doesn't diminish their abilities or accomplishments. It's important to grieve if needed, share feelings with loved ones, and move forward to other opportunities rather than fixating on closed doors.

3.Question

What advice can be given to students placed on a waitlist?

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Answer:For waitlisted students, it's crucial to stay 'active' by expressing continued interest, maintain strong academic performance to boost their transcripts, and stay engaged with admissions officers without being overbearing. They should also consider other schools as viable options.

4.Question

What can parents do to support their children during the college admissions process?

Answer:Parents should provide emotional support and encourage their children to express their own feelings and take charge of their college admissions experience, rather than speaking on their behalf, which can be detrimental.

5.Question

What is the significance of normalizing college rejection?

Answer:Normalizing rejection helps remove stigma and allows students to see it as a common experience rather than a personal failure. Initiatives like rejection walls within schools promote discussions that can alleviate feelings of isolation and inadequacy.

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6.Question

How does the admissions process reflect broader societal values around achievement?

Answer:The competitive nature of college admissions highlights societal pressures around academic success and prestige. Understanding that many capable students will be rejected can encourage a healthier perspective on achievement and the diverse paths one can take.

7.Question

Why do some students struggle with their college choices even after being admitted?

Answer:Students may feel conflicted about their college choices due to societal expectations, comparisons with peers, or a fixation on schools they were denied. They might underestimate their other excellent options based on these external pressures.

8.Question

How can personal experiences with rejection influence future success?

Answer:Experiencing rejection can foster resilience, helping

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students to adapt and explore new paths that they may not have considered otherwise. Often, unforeseen opportunities may lead to fulfilling experiences beyond their initial aspirations.

9.Question

What key lesson about belonging can students learn from the college admissions process?

Answer:Belonging is complex; students may feel they belong to a certain institution, but this isn't always aligned with the admissions decision. Learning that there are many places where one can flourish expands a student's perspective and acceptance of diverse outcomes.

10.Question

How can students express their interest to a college after being waitlisted?

Answer:Students can express their interest by sending a simple email to their regional admissions officer indicating their excitement about the college and updating them on any new academic or extracurricular accomplishments.

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Chapter 17 | Admitted Student Events| Q&A

1.Question

What should students consider when choosing a college?

Answer:Students should consider personal needs like financial aid, location, academic programs, campus culture, and specific amenities (like pet policies). It's important that the decision aligns with what feels right for them and their future aspirations.

2.Question

What is the importance of choosing a college that aligns with personal values?

Answer:Choosing a college that resonates with one's values ensures a more fulfilling experience, allowing students to thrive academically and socially. As mentioned, choices can be influenced by factors such as job security or community engagement, which reflect personal priorities.

3.Question

How can students advocate for themselves during the college selection process?

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Answer: Students can reach out to admissions offices if they have concerns about their experience, appeal financial aid packages, or request an extension for their 'intent to enroll' if needed. It's crucial for students to speak up about what they need.

4.Question

Why is it significant for students to understand that there isn't just one 'right' college?

Answer: Recognizing that there are multiple institutions that can offer a great education liberates students from the pressure of a singular choice and encourages them to focus on making the most out of their college experience, regardless of the name or prestige of the institution.

5.Question

What does the author suggest about the reasons behind a student's college choice?

Answer: The author emphasizes that individuals have unique and personal reasons for their college decisions, whether it's financial situations or personal circumstances. It's essential

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to respect these choices as ultimately being right for the student making them.

6.Question

How might campus visit experiences influence a student's choice of college?

Answer:Campus visits can significantly shape a student's perceptions, as friendly or unfriendly experiences can impact their enthusiasm about a college. It highlights the importance of presenting a welcoming atmosphere during these visits.

7.Question

What is the overarching message conveyed about the college decision-making process?

Answer:The message is that students should embrace the opportunity to choose a college that is the best fit for their unique circumstances, understanding that many paths can lead to success.

8.Question

What can be learned from the author's own college choice experience?

Answer:The author reflects on how initial perceptions can be

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misleading; engaging with different people and experiences at a chosen college can reveal its true nature and benefits.

9.Question

What advice does the author give to students feeling overwhelmed by their college choices?

Answer:The simplest advice is to choose one college and commit to it fully. Moving forward with a decision allows students to focus on making the most of their new opportunity.

10.Question

How does the author suggest colleges can support admitted students in their decision-making?

Answer:Colleges should provide clear information, create engaging visiting experiences, be open to resolving issues, and offer financial aid assistance to help ease the decision for admitted students.

Chapter 18 | Welcome to College| Q&A

1.Question

What lesson can we learn from the author's cheerleading experience?

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Answer: The author learned that being chosen for a team doesn't define one's worth; it simply means you were the right fit for a specific role at that moment. It's essential to embrace the opportunity and grow from it, rather than comparing oneself to others.

2.Question

What is the author's perspective on the concept of 'deserving' in college admissions?

Answer: The author believes that the concept of 'deserving' is misleading, as admissions decisions are not based on who is more deserving but rather on the college's needs and goals in creating a diverse and balanced class.

3.Question

Why does the author want first-year students to recognize college as a privilege?

Answer: The author emphasizes the importance of recognizing college as a privilege because it requires maximizing the opportunities available, which were made

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possible by the investments of the college, families, and the students themselves.

4.Question

What is the significance of Christopher's journey during his college years?

Answer:Christopher exemplified the ideal college experience by actively participating in various activities, exploring opportunities, and fully engaging with the resources his college offered. His journey illustrates how students can enrich their lives and personal growth by making the most of their time in college.

5.Question

How does the author suggest students approach their college experience?

Answer:The author advises students to embrace their college experience by getting involved, seeking mentorship, capitalizing on available opportunities, and being open to trying new things, which fosters personal and academic growth.

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6.Question

What does the author regret about her own college experience?

Answer:The author expresses regret for not taking more risks, such as trying out for the improv group or building relationships with professors, highlighting the importance of seizing opportunities when they arise.

7.Question

What role do college staff play in supporting first-year students?

Answer:College staff play a significant role in facilitating a supportive environment for first-year students by ensuring resources are available and encouraging engagement in activities that enhance learning and personal development.

8.Question

What was the author's impression of the first-year students at Dartmouth?

Answer:The author viewed the first-year students with nostalgia, relating to their anxiety and excitement while recognizing their potential as the 'chosen ones' who had

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worked hard to be in that position.

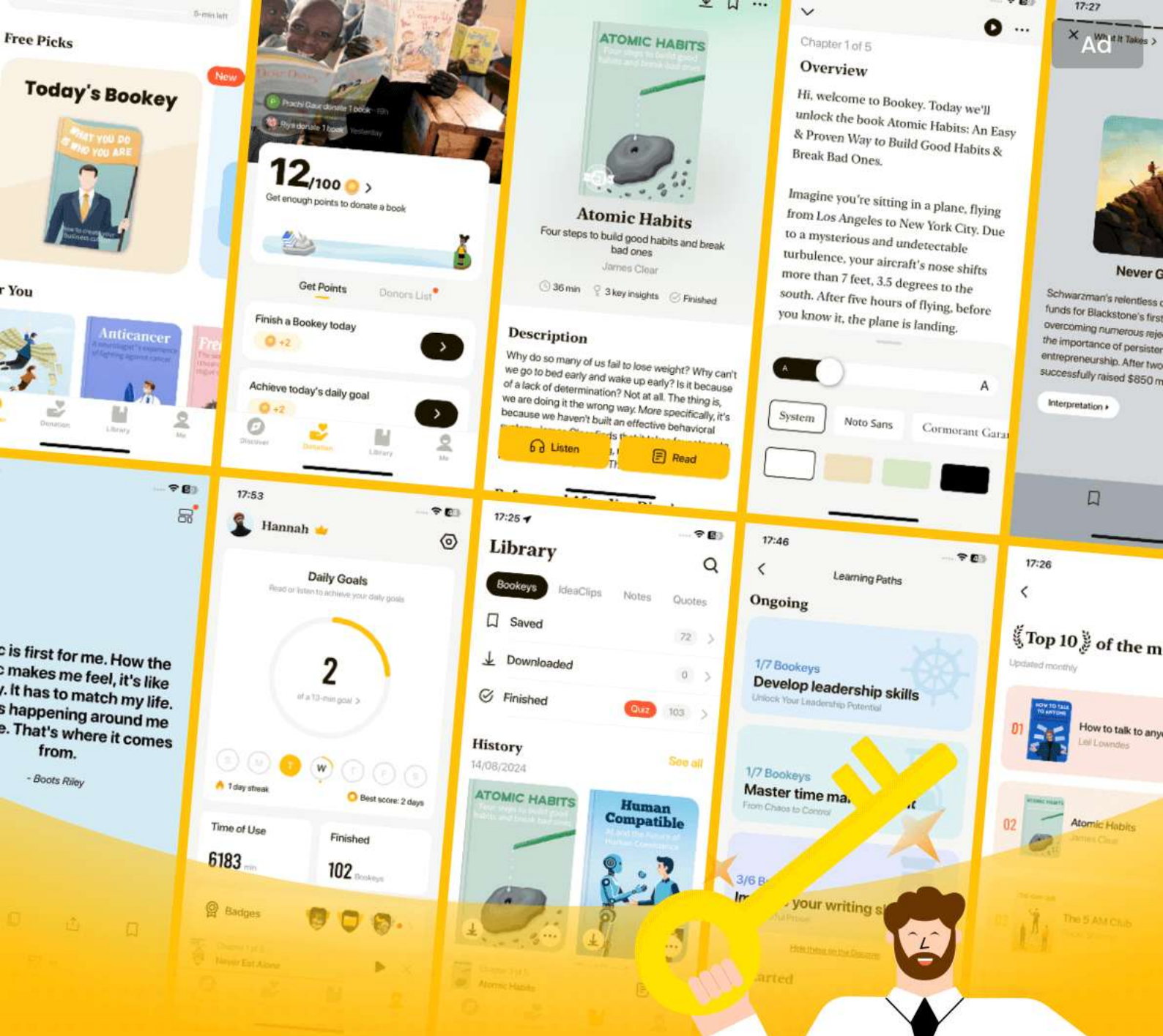
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Chapter 19 | Best in Class| Q&A

1.Question

What is the main message Becky Munsterer Sabky conveys about the college admissions process?

Answer: The main message is that the college admissions process has become overly focused on numbers, accolades, and competitiveness, often overshadowing the importance of character, decency, and genuine experiences. She emphasizes the need for students to reassess what 'impressiveness' truly means and to recognize that beyond statistics, meaningful actions—like kindness and empathy—carry much more weight.

2.Question

How does the author illustrate the importance of decency in her narrative?

Answer: The author illustrates the importance of decency through the actions of a young valet named Ernie, who stops to save a frog from being squished. Unlike the various

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impressive applicants she encounters who are more focused on their resumes, Ernie's caring gesture demonstrates that true impressiveness lies in actions that show kindness and empathy.

3.Question

What perspective does Sabky want others to gain about the college application process?

Answer: Sabky wants others to understand that the admissions process often does not reflect the worth of a student as a person. She encourages a shift away from an obsession with elite institutions and rankings and towards recognizing the value of caring individuals and diverse educational experiences.

4.Question

In what ways does the author suggest students can change their approach to college admissions?

Answer: The author suggests that students should focus on preparing themselves genuinely for college rather than merely presenting themselves as impressive candidates. They

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should engage sincerely with the application process, prioritize meaningful extracurricular activities over a lengthy list of achievements, and recognize that being part of a community and having character matters far more than merely gaining acceptance at prestigious schools.

5.Question

How does the author define her ideal success for her children?

Answer:The author defines success for her children as being kind, decent, and valuable members of society rather than merely attending prestigious colleges. She emphasizes that while education is important, character and the ability to connect with others—and to be caring and sympathetic—are what truly define an individual's impressiveness.

6.Question

What does Sabky mean when she says, 'Being smart is valued. But being decent is impressive.'?

Answer:Sabky means that while academic intelligence and achieving high grades are certainly commendable and

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valuable, it is the quality of being kind, compassionate, and decent towards others that stands out and makes a lasting impact. She advocates for nurturing both intelligence and decency in her children.

Chapter 20 | Notes 4| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of the Fly-In program mentioned in the chapter?

Answer:The Fly-In program is significant because it offers subsidized visits to campus for students from defined backgrounds and/or low socioeconomic status. This initiative aims to provide these students with opportunities that they might not otherwise have, helping to diversify the student body and create a more inclusive college environment.

2.Question

How does the chapter portray the culture of college admissions with regard to 'demonstrated interest'?

Answer:The chapter highlights the problematic nature of

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tracking 'demonstrated interest' in college admissions. It points out that less-resourced students often lack opportunities to show their commitment to a school, creating an uneven playing field. This practice can lead to a culture of obsession where students feel pressured to prove their interest in often superficial ways.

3.Question

What does the description of the Dartmouth lobby convey about the college's atmosphere?

Answer: The description of the Dartmouth lobby reveals a contrast to more welcoming college environments. While other institutions may offer inviting features like warmth and comfort, Dartmouth's lobby once had old and dusty furniture, suggesting a more austere or less hospitable atmosphere. This change reflects an awareness of the importance of first impressions in the admissions process.

4.Question

Why might eavesdropping on campus interactions be considered beneficial, according to the author?

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Answer:Eavesdropping on campus interactions can be beneficial because it allows the admissions team to gauge genuine student experiences and sentiments about the college. This practice can provide valuable insights into the campus culture and community that might not be conveyed through formal channels, helping to attract a more authentic cohort of students.

5.Question

What connection does the chapter make between Dartmouth and the broader context of college experiences?

Answer:The chapter connects Dartmouth to broader college experiences by referencing its history and notable alumni like Dr. Seuss, which enriches its identity. Moreover, it reflects on aspects like weather realities, infrastructure resembling other institutions, and unique campus traditions, all of which are part of the collective collegiate experience that shapes students' lives.

6.Question

What lesson can prospective students learn from the

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anecdote about the polar bear animation?

Answer: Prospective students can learn the importance of authenticity and relevance when representing a college's values. The humorous yet telling anecdote about the polar bear animation reminds students that what may be intended as an innovative display can sometimes backfire, emphasizing the need for genuine representations of the institution's commitments.

Chapter 21 | Notes 6| Q&A

1.Question

What role can high school counselors play in shaping a student's future, and how does this differ between public and private schools?

Answer: High school counselors can play a crucial role in helping students navigate the college application process, offering guidance on college choices, and providing emotional support. In private schools, counselors often have more time and resources to dedicate to individual students, which

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means they can develop deeper relationships and provide more tailored advice. In contrast, public school counselors may be overwhelmed due to high student-to-counselor ratios, which can limit their ability to offer personalized guidance. This disparity underscores the need for equity in educational resources, pushing for improvements in public education systems.

2.Question

How did a teacher influence the author's desire to pursue writing?

Answer: The author credits a particular teacher, known for being a hard grader, with inspiring their passion for writing. By insisting on high standards and focusing on details like grammar and structure, this teacher helped the author appreciate the craft of writing. The teacher's thorough approach not only improved the author's writing skills but also instilled a lasting impact, showcasing how passionate teaching can ignite a student's ambitions.

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3.Question

What does the author wish they had communicated to the college admissions committee about their high school experience?

Answer: The author regrets not expressing to the admissions committee the pride they felt in attending their high school, which had an average academic record. They wish they had highlighted the value of their diverse experiences, such as riding the bus with students from different backgrounds, which enriched their understanding of the world.

Additionally, the author wanted to share the joy of taking a class with their sibling, emphasizing the lessons learned beyond traditional academics.

4.Question

In what ways can experiencing diversity in school environments contribute to a student's development?

Answer: Experiencing diversity in school settings can significantly enhance a student's social and personal growth. Being exposed to peers from varying backgrounds fosters empathy, broadens perspectives, and encourages

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open-mindedness. It also prepares students for real-world interactions in multicultural settings, helping them develop skills that are critical in a globally interconnected society. Learning alongside diverse peers can often impart life lessons that academic subjects alone cannot teach.

5.Question

What is the message of the author regarding the state of arts education in schools?

Answer: The author emphasizes the importance of arts education, particularly in light of budget cuts that threaten these programs. This highlights a broader concern about how educational institutions prioritize certain subjects over others, often at the expense of holistic student development. By advocating for the arts as meaningful academic subjects, the author underscores the need for a well-rounded education that nurtures creativity alongside traditional academics.

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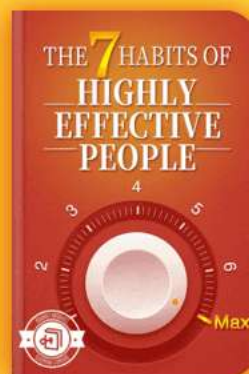
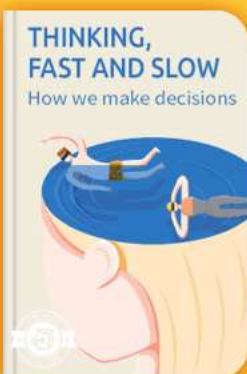


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Chapter 22 | Notes 17| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of adding a personal touch to admission letters?

Answer: Adding a handwritten personal note to admission letters creates a connection between the school and the student, making the acceptance feel more genuine and welcoming. It shows that the admissions team cares about each applicant as an individual, rather than just a number.

2.Question

How can a gap year benefit students before attending college?

Answer: A gap year can provide students with valuable experiences that help them grow personally and gain maturity. It allows them the opportunity to work, travel, or volunteer, which can give them a clearer sense of purpose and direction when they finally enter college, making their academic experience more meaningful.

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3.Question

What can students gain by being honest about their intended major on their applications?

Answer:Being honest about intended majors—even if undecided—helps admissions teams gauge applicants more accurately and reduces the risk of making an ill-informed choice later on. It encourages students to consider their interests seriously and can lead to a better match between them and the academic programs offered.

4.Question

Why is applying to all eight Ivy League schools viewed as elitist?

Answer:Applying to all eight Ivies suggests a lack of understanding or appreciation for the unique qualities and cultures of different institutions. It comes off as an elitist attitude, as the motivation seems to stem more from prestige than from genuine interest in the school's specific values or programs.

5.Question

What lessons can be learned from the idea that even

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mistakes in applications can be revisited?

Answer: The ability to revisit application mistakes teaches the importance of diligence and fairness in admissions processes. It suggests that circumstances can change and that individuals deserve a second chance, highlighting the value of thorough review and compassion in decision-making.

6.Question

What is the main point about the waitlist process outlined in the chapter?

Answer: The waitlist process shows how selective and competitive admissions can be, where only a small percentage of applicants are offered a place. It emphasizes the uncertainty and pressure students face, reiterating that admissions decisions are based on holistic evaluations.

7.Question

Why did the author mention the practice of donating gift cards?

Answer: The mention of donating gift cards points to the ethics and policies surrounding gifts in the admissions

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process. It humorously showcases the conflict between professional responsibility and personal desire, illustrating the human side of the admissions process.

Chapter 23 | Notes 19| Q&A

1.Question

What can we learn from the author's experience of being nervous before starting college?

Answer:It's natural to feel anxious before a significant change like starting college. However, having a supportive environment, like friendly roommates, can ease those nerves and help you adapt to new situations.

2.Question

What does the author's husband's commitment to attending classes teach us about educational investment?

Answer:His dedication to not missing classes highlights the importance of valuing education as an investment. It shows that persistence and dedication, even when faced with challenges like being hungover or sick, can lead to success.

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3.Question

How does the author reflect on her past words when welcoming international students?

Answer:The author expresses regret for labeling international students as 'the best and brightest,' suggesting that such language can unintentionally detract from the diverse talents and experiences that all students bring to the campus.

4.Question

Why is participation in college events, despite initial reluctance, significant according to the author?

Answer:Participation in college events fosters community and connection among students. It not only enhances the college experience but also encourages students to step out of their comfort zones and engage with peers.

5.Question

What does Christopher's experience after college reveal about maintaining connections from school?

Answer:After college, staying connected with friends can become challenging due to life changes and responsibilities. It emphasizes the importance of nurturing friendships and

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finding new ways to engage in activities we enjoyed during school.

6.Question

In what ways does the author's reminiscence about her college experience encourage first-year students?

Answer: The author's recollections serve as a reminder that college is a time of growth and that initial anxieties can lead to forming lifelong friendships and unforgettable memories. Embracing these moments, despite initial fear, is vital for personal development.

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Chapter 1 | First Steps| Quiz and Test

1. Families should start engaging in the college process by the end of junior year to avoid stress during senior year.
2. Students should prioritize getting into prestigious institutions over gaining a well-rounded perspective on college.
3. High school success is directly related to opportunities in college.

Chapter 2 | Creating the Right College List| Quiz and Test

1. Students only need to focus on prestigious colleges when creating their college list.
2. It is essential for students to include a variety of colleges in their application list to ensure they have sufficient options.
3. Financial considerations are not a significant factor when choosing which colleges to apply to.

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Chapter 3 | The Campus Visit| Quiz and Test

- 1.College visits in America are primarily designed to provide a whimsical experience with little practical insight into college life.
- 2.It's important for students who can visit campuses to plan strategically and to engage with the campus environment beyond scheduled events.
- 3.Engaging with current students and faculty during campus visits is discouraged as it may lead to misinformation about the college culture.

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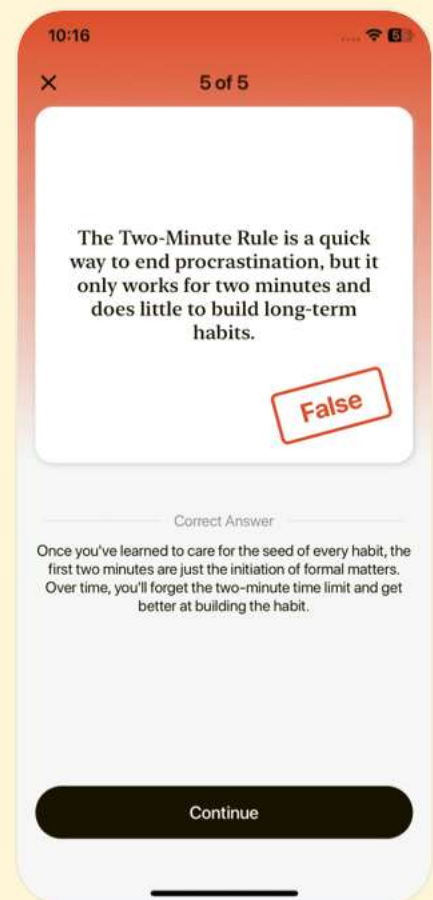
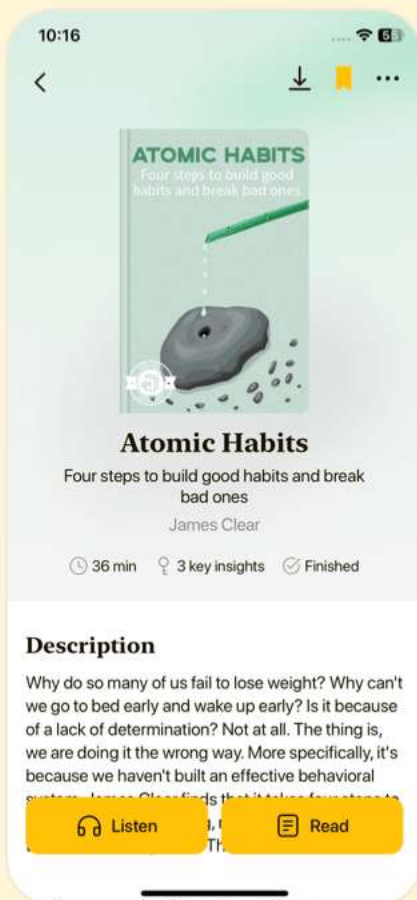


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Chapter 4 | Coming to a High School Near You| Quiz and Test

- 1.The author believes that knowing the admissions officer can benefit applicants in the admissions process.
- 2.The author only focuses on the academic achievements of students during her recruitment process.
- 3.The chapter suggests that unique candidates like Layla may miss opportunities if they do not apply.

Chapter 5 | The School Report| Quiz and Test

- 1.Colleges value students from a variety of educational backgrounds equally.
- 2.Students are discouraged from pursuing courses that align with their interests if they do not impress admissions committees.
- 3.Admissions officers only consider a student's grades and test scores, disregarding the context of their school environment.

Chapter 6 | Recommendations| Quiz and Test

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- 1.Recommendations play a crucial role in the college admissions process, providing insights beyond academic performance. True or False?
- 2.Teacher recommendations are unimportant in holistic admissions reviews. True or False?
- 3.Students should avoid building relationships with teachers when seeking recommendations. True or False?

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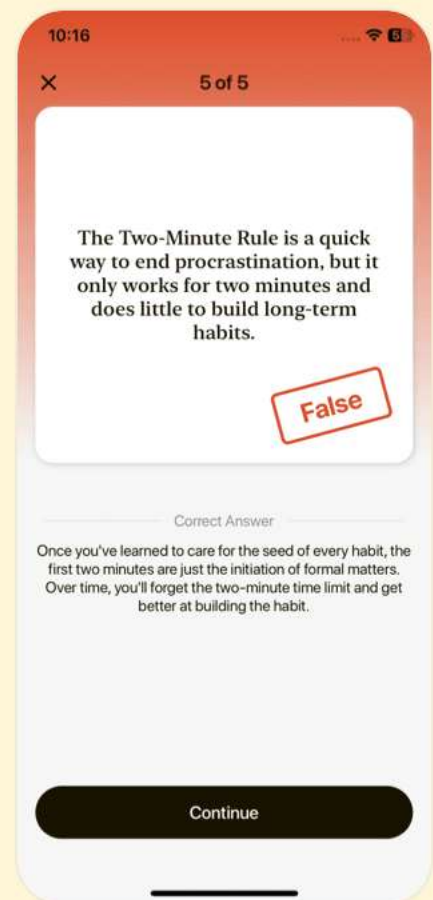
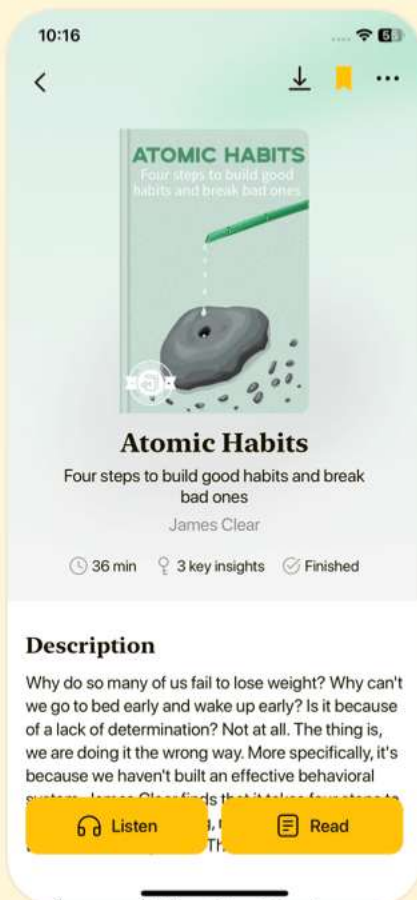


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Chapter 7 | Extracurriculars| Quiz and Test

1. Students should participate in extracurricular activities out of genuine interest rather than obligation.
2. Admissions officers are primarily interested in the quantity of extracurricular activities rather than their authenticity.
3. Engaging in non-competitive personal activities is discouraged as it may take away time from accumulating accolades.

Chapter 8 | Testing| Quiz and Test

1. Students' worth and identity are often defined solely by their standardized test scores.
2. Research indicates that standardized test scores are not influenced by socioeconomic factors and race.
3. Colleges like Dartmouth conduct a holistic review of applications, considering test scores along with other components.

Chapter 9 | The Personal Statement| Quiz and Test

1. The personal statement should focus on seeking

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shock value to stand out.

2.Using detailed anecdotes can enhance the impact of a personal statement.

3.Each essay should reflect a student's individual experiences and be unique among submissions.

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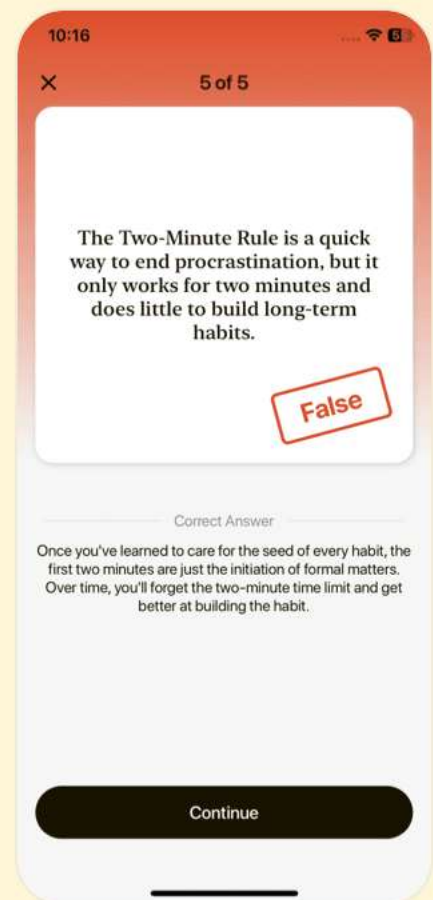
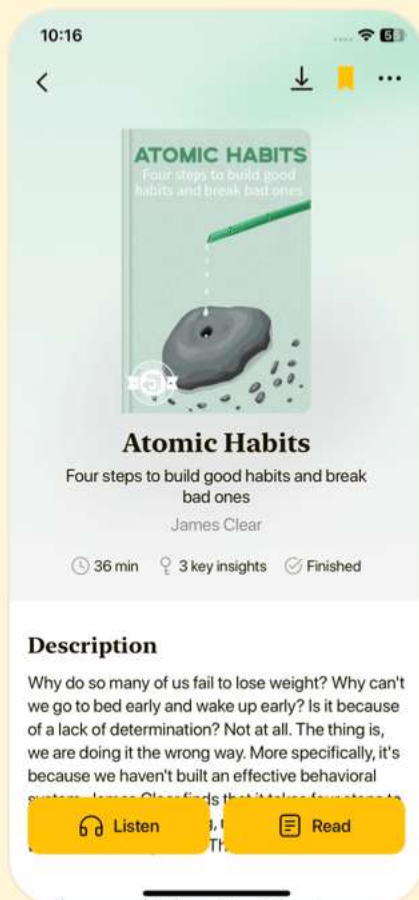


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Chapter 10 | Supplemental Essays| Quiz and Test

- 1.Colleges require supplemental essays in addition to personal statements during the application process.
- 2.Supplemental essays do not provide insights into applicants beyond grades and scores.
- 3.Students universally enjoy writing supplemental essays as they find them easy and enjoyable.

Chapter 11 | Submitting the Application| Quiz and Test

- 1.Colleges admit students based on their needs for a specific class, focusing on the overall candidacy rather than minor errors.
- 2.Admissions officers spend an average of thirty minutes reviewing applications, emphasizing the importance of thorough and detailed submissions.
- 3.Students should be careful with their social media profiles as a negative online presence can affect admissions decisions.

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Chapter 12 | Alumni Interviews| Quiz and Test

- 1.Alumni interviews are conducted only after a student's application is complete.
- 2.Most alumni interviews are held in private settings to ensure confidentiality.
- 3.Negative interview experiences are less impactful on the admissions process compared to positive ones.

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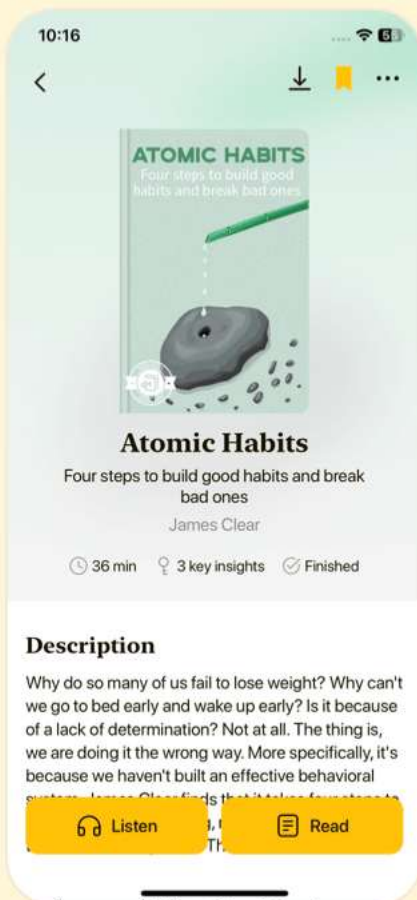


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Chapter 13 | A Word on Early| Quiz and Test

1. Early applications to colleges generally enhance a student's chances of acceptance.
2. Early Decision (ED) applicants can compare financial aid offers from different schools.
3. Students who apply early are guaranteed their application will be reviewed later if deferred.

Chapter 14 | International Applicants| Quiz and Test

1. International applicants are defined as those who possess a U.S. passport.
2. The acceptance rate for international students at Dartmouth is about 2%.
3. Colleges consider financial aid needs as a significant factor for international applicants during admissions.

Chapter 15 | Recruited Athletes| Quiz and Test

1. Recruited athletes at Dartmouth do not have to meet the same academic standards as nonathlete applicants.
2. Coaches communicate directly with athletes and their

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families during the admissions process.

3. Athletes should focus on academics and take challenging courses during the recruitment process.

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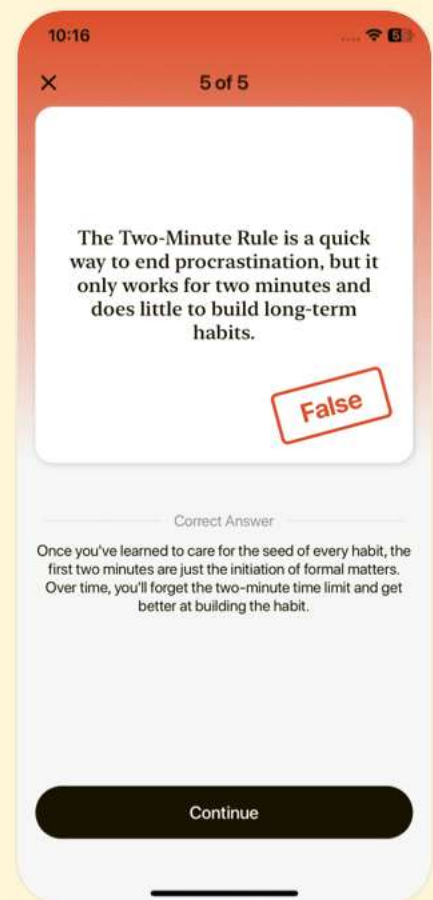
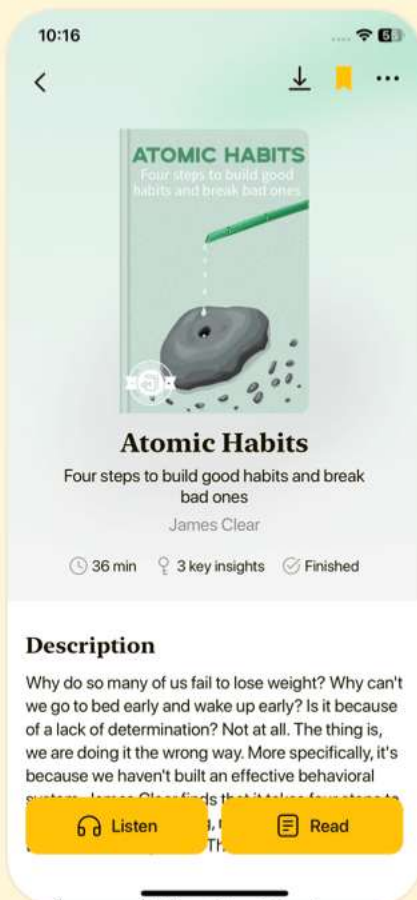


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Chapter 16 | Decision Day| Quiz and Test

1. Decision day elicits a range of emotions from students, including gratitude and disappointment.
2. Admissions representatives often change rejection decisions based on emotional pleas from students or parents.
3. It is important for students to feel that rejection diminishes their achievements when applying to colleges.

Chapter 17 | Admitted Student Events| Quiz and Test

1. Regular decision admits face a tight deadline to select a college, with admissions notifications typically sent in late March and a May 1 deadline for intent to enroll.
2. The decision-making process for college selection is solely based on financial considerations and job security.
3. The author encourages students to take ownership of their decision-making process and suggests appealing financial aid offers if necessary.

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Chapter 18 | Welcome to College| Quiz and Test

- 1.The author believes that being selected for a varsity cheerleading team guarantees that one is more skilled than others.
- 2.The author emphasizes the importance of maximizing the opportunity of attending a prestigious institution like Dartmouth.
- 3.The author's role as an admissions officer is solely based on which students deserve to be accepted into college.

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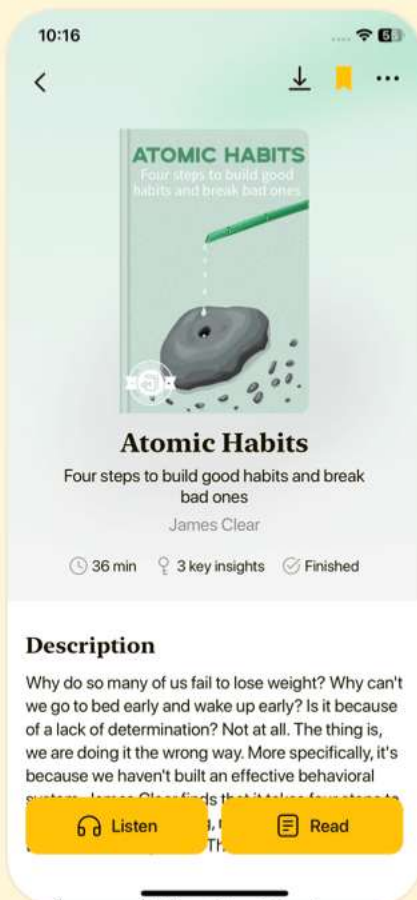


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Chapter 19 | Best in Class| Quiz and Test

- 1.The author believes that college admissions should prioritize legacy admissions to maintain traditions.
- 2.After having her son, the author feels liberated to engage openly with families about college options.
- 3.The author emphasizes that impressive resume building should be the top priority for students applying to colleges.

Chapter 20 | Notes 4| Quiz and Test

- 1.Many students aspire to careers such as CSI investigators according to college fairs.
- 2.Fly-In programs are only available to privileged students.
- 3.Dartmouth is notable for the invention of the BASIC programming language in 1964.

Chapter 21 | Notes 6| Quiz and Test

- 1.Approximately 90 percent of American high school students attended private schools in 2015.
- 2.The author values the diverse experiences gained from attending a public high school.
- 3.Public school counselors provide more personalized

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support to students than private school counselors.

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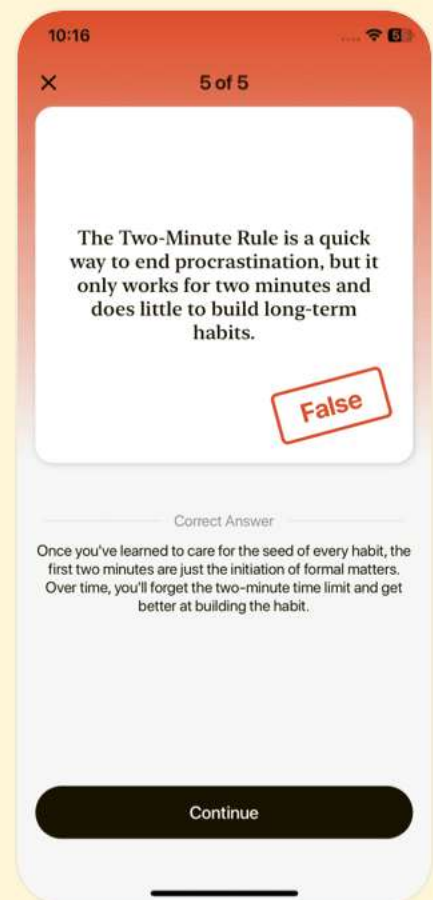
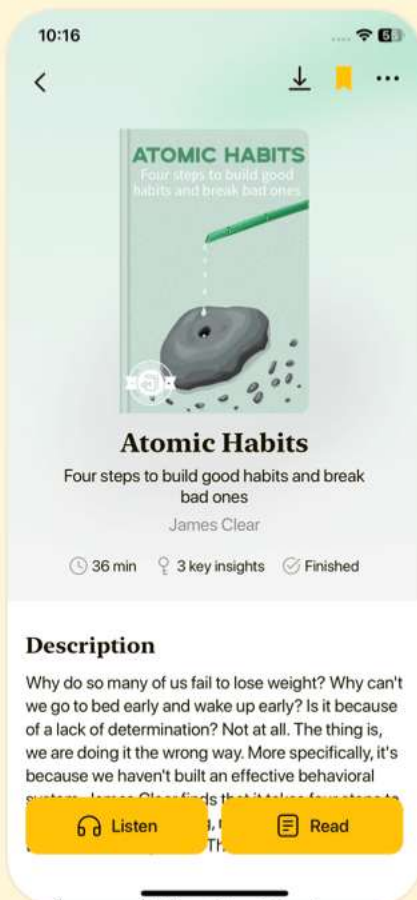


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Chapter 22 | Notes 17| Quiz and Test

1. Handwritten notes were occasionally added to admit letters to personalize communication with incoming students, inviting them to campus.
2. Dartmouth's wait list acceptance rate is over 10% of applicants offered a place.
3. Applying to all eight Ivy League schools is considered standard practice due to their similarities.

Chapter 23 | Notes 19| Quiz and Test

1. The author received numerous invitations to graduation parties throughout college, similar to the high school senior plays.
2. The author's husband dedicated himself to attending classes, rarely missing them throughout his college years.
3. Before college, the author felt relaxed and confident while spending the night in a Holiday Inn bathroom.

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